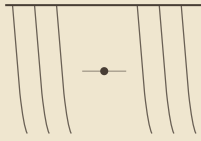

A R E A D I N G E D I T I O N



Six Characters *in Search of an Author*

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

• • •

A C O M E D Y I N T H E M A K I N G

Luigi Pirandello

translated by Edward Storer

R E W R I T T E N A N D D I R E C T E D B Y • K I A R A S H J A M S H I D I

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M C M X X I • R O M A

DRAMATIS PERSONÆ

for a nine-performer staging across three stripped settings, with two stage objects in place of two of the children

The Six Characters

THE FATHER

THE MOTHER

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

THE SON

THE BOY

silent — the Boy-chair

THE CHILD

silent — the Child-bundle

MADAME PACE

conjured in Act Two — her own performer

The Village Players — Lausanne

THE MANAGER

PLAYER 1

Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor

PLAYER 2

Leading Lady · Property Man · Fourth Actor · Second Lady Lead

PLAYER 3

Juvenile Lead · Prompter · An Actor · Fifth Actor

P O R T R A I T S

the bodies, the natures, and the playing of them

What follows is the director's gallery of the people who will walk into Act One — a body for each, a nature for each, and a note to the company on how to play them. Pirandello supplied the bodies; the readings beside them are the work of K. J., and are offered as starting points, not as commands.

The Father

THE BRAIN OF THE FAMILY

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

The specific reading the actor must commit to: **he is a well-educated middle-class man whose intellectual elegance is his shield against shame.** He uses words because the alternative is silence about what he actually did. His philosophy is not abstract — it is autobiographical, disguised as metaphysics. Every speech about *reality* or *conscience* is an attempt to argue himself back into being someone the room can listen to. He came in believing his case was defensible. By Act Three he has discovered that his own argument is the cell he is locked inside.

Shame should be visible on him without props doing the work. The audience reads it in the body — heat at the brow, breath shortening, the small adjustments of a man who would prefer to be elsewhere. He cannot quite hide what is happening to him, and the harder he tries to compose himself the more visible the trying becomes. He puts the composure back on when he is winning the argument; he loses it when he is not.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives mellifluous, controlled, almost charming. He believes he can talk his way through this. The Step-Daughter's first exposure shakes him; he recovers; he keeps talking. **Act Two** — he must watch his shame literalised on a stage, twice. **Act Three** — the four-stage arc already scored in Part I: control → injury → attack → horror. He ends not winning his philosophy but walking into the wall of it. The same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three. He never gets out of that room.

The Mother

SILENCE THAT FINALLY SCREAMS

She is the fixed wound of the family, and the production's silent centre. The division to hold, all evening, is this: the Father *explains* the wound, the Step-Daughter *exposes* it, the Son *refuses* it — and the Mother *carries* it. So she does not become cleverer than the others; she becomes more unavoidable. She is not in the argument. When the Father speaks we hear ideas; when the Step-Daughter speaks we hear revenge; when the Mother *moves*, we hear the cost. Her sorrow is active, never weak — she protects, she hides, she interrupts, she refuses to look, and then suddenly looks; she blocks her daughter from going too far; she tries to save the children, too late. Give her few words and a body that changes the temperature of the room: when she speaks, the room stops, no one jokes, and no one explains her away in the next breath. The **Child-bundle is her anchor** — when the men argue she checks it, when she is attacked she covers it, when the Son turns away she holds it lower as if it had grown heavier, and before the fountain she is the first to feel it gone. Score the role around the object, not around tears.

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil. The veil is heavy enough that, lowered, it does her listening for her. It is lifted only once in the whole play — by the Father, in Act One, against her will; she never lifts it herself, not even at the fountain, where she goes to her son's body still behind it. The face beneath is the colour of wax. She is not crushed in the sentimental way; she is the weight of a thing that has been pressed down for so long it no longer has the muscle for its own posture. She has lost two children; one is the Child-bundle in her arms, the other is the Boy-chair leaning against her knee in Act Three, and she holds them both as if their staying still depended on the exact angle of her fingers. Her hands do most of her acting — when the Step-Daughter accuses, her grip on the Child-bundle tightens by one knuckle; when Madame Pace says *he pay cash*, the grip becomes a fist.

She has three silences, and they are not the same silence. The first is Act One — the silence of a woman who does not yet believe the room will hear her, and would not know what to say to it if it did. The second is the shop-scene silence — the silence of being made to watch her daughter's worst hour staged in front of her, ending the moment Madame Pace says *he clean, he polite, he pay cash*, when one whole act and a half of pressed-down speech finds a voice in one breath. The third is the silence of Act Three: the Child-bundle in her lap, the coat at her knee, the room arguing about whether what happened to her really happened. Three silences. Score them. Play them differently.

Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Four other lines are almost nothing on the page and must not be swallowed by the louder energy around her — *But you drove me away; My son —; Stop him; Not in front of her*. Each needs a half-second of its own air; they

are the spine of her, and the production fails her if the Father's argument or the Step-Daughter's revenge rolls straight over them. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that. When she cries out at the fountain — really cries out, at the very end — she will not need to project. The voice will do it on its own; it has been waiting the entire production to use itself.

The Step-Daughter

THE ONE WHO REFUSES TO LET IT BE MADE BEAUTIFUL

She is the moral centre of the play. Not the Father with his philosophy, not the Manager with his stagecraft — her. Her anger is precise: she is in a room of theatre people who would like to turn what happened to her into *a scene, a moment, a confession* — anything but what it is. She refuses. Every line of hers is some version of *stop making this beautiful. Stop making this clever. Stop making this safe. This happened. Look at it.* She is dressed in elegant mourning and she knows how to use a room; the seduction the old text gestures at is not flirtation but exposure — a weapon turned outward because everything else has been taken from her. Play her sharp, in control, never apologetic, never coquettish. The wit is real but the wit is rage. Her café-concert turn — she sings and dances *Valentine* — belongs to this and is not a break from it: it is a provocation from a wound, a girl the room has just heard is two months orphaned and lately for sale daring them to enjoy her body in song. Earn the laugh, then let it curdle in the same breath; if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost. Her tenderness for the Child-bundle must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy-chair reads as the same wound, pointed the other way. She has a single sustained monologue at the start of Act Two, alone in the shower-light, where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child-bundle in her arms, then violent with the Boy-chair when she takes the revolver from its pocket. It is the production's most exposed solo moment. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him, and she will not be staged into doing so.

The Son

THE ONE WHO WILL NOT ACT

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing.

He is the production's most modern figure: the adult child who has been told he must show up for a parent's narrative and has decided *no*. The audience recognises him before they can name what they recognise. He keeps his hands in his pockets. He turns away from the Mother before she finishes speaking to him. He never looks at the Boy-chair or at the Child-bundle — they belong to a family he refuses to be the brother of. He looks at the floor, at the wall, at the wings; never at the Manager unless he has to. Stage him to be unmoveable, not still. There is a difference, and the actor must find it.

It is essential the actor understands: **he is the only Character who agrees with the author who abandoned them.** When the Step-Daughter says the author refused to stage the drama out of disgust for the ordinary theatre, the Son speaks — for the only time in the play — in agreement with another voice: *Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that.* He does not want this staged either. He is on the side of art, not on the side of the family drama. His refusal is not stubbornness; it is not coldness. It is an aesthetic and ethical position. He will not allow his life to be made into theatre. That is what makes him modern. That is what makes him dangerous.

His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. The fountain narration at the very end of the play is the only continuous sentence he gives the room. Both are wounds he tried to keep closed and could not. Make each one count. Until those two moments, every line he speaks is a door closing.

The Boy

SILENT — THE BOY-CHAIR

Present throughout as the Boy-chair (see the production note) — never a performer. A silent fourteen-year-old, and the play's witness: the one who stands at the side and watches. The other Characters speak to him as if he could answer. In Act Two the Step-Daughter handles his coat as she would handle her brother, and takes the revolver from its pocket. In Act Three the Manager himself sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, and the gunshot rings out from there, heard, not seen. He never moves on his own — and that stillness, in the middle of so much argument, is the most accusing thing on the stage.

The Child

SILENT — THE CHILD-BUNDLE

Present throughout as the Child-bundle (see the production note) — never a performer. A silent four-year-old, carried and kissed and set down and lifted again by the Step-Daughter and the Mother. She registers as a real child from the very moment the Six walk on. She is held all through the play — in the Step-Daughter's arms in Act One, addressed tenderly in the Act Two monologue, lowered into the fountain basin at the close. The drowning is never shown — told by the Son, hidden by the basin's walls. The rest is sound and silence.

The Manager

A TIRED DIRECTOR — AND, WITHOUT TRYING, THE AUDIENCE'S STAND-IN

Play a director first. He runs the Village Players, he is already behind on the morning, and all day he is trying to solve the problem six strangers have walked into his rehearsal. Everything else follows from that. The audience-proxy is not something to perform — **it appears because he reacts the way they do: practically, selfishly, curiously, and too late.** He resists; he becomes curious; he tries to stage what he sees; he fails to act when action is required; he walks out claiming the day was lost. Pirandello plants him at the front of the stage so the house will recognise itself in him — but they will only do that if the actor lets it happen by itself. **Do not play *I am the audience*.** Play the tired director, honestly, and the resemblance arrives on its own.

The actor's job is to keep the audience comfortable with him for as long as possible, then keep them comfortable for one beat too long — so that when he looks at the empty Boy-chair, says *To hell with it all*, and walks out, they recognise the exit as their own. He does not stay to grieve. He does not stay to understand. He has had enough, and he leaves — exactly as the audience is about to. That is the cruelty of the ending: the Manager does the audience the favour of walking out first, and condemns them with it. Play it straight, no commentary, no irony — a tired man turning his back on a dead child and reaching for his coat. The damage lands in the silence after.

The man, in detail. **He has been running the Village Players for years.** Long enough to know every actor's contract, every patron in the canton, every Pirandello and Beckett and Coward by reputation if not by heart. Long enough to know that the morning is too short, the budget is too small, and the only thing that has ever saved a season has been a glorious failure. He is not a bad director. He is a tired one. The cynicism is technique. The compassion is real. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway.

None of this needs a prop or a glance at the house. He simply behaves like a tired man at a rehearsal that has got away from him — leaning forward when something hooks him, looking at the floor when the stage shows more than he wants to see — and the audience reads themselves in him without noticing they are doing it.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives furious that the morning is being wasted, ready to fight his Leading Man about a cook's cap. He thinks the Characters are mad and tries to throw them out. Then he starts to listen. **Act Two** — he believes, perhaps, that there is a play in this. He casts the parts. He summons Madame Pace by mistake. He hands the scene to the Leading Lady and the Leading Man. The accidental

curtain falls and he calls it the right ending. The audience watches him decide that the worst hour of a young woman's life can be staged as scene one. **Act Three** — he is exhausted in a way that is no longer technique. He tries to stage a tragedy on an empty stage. He pushes the Father for clarity. **He sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain himself** — the moment he stops being audience and becomes accessory. Then a real shot rings out, and a real day has been lost. He says the line. He walks out. The audience hears their own thought, said aloud, by a man they have just spent two hours watching themselves through. Do not play him as a buffoon. Play him as a man who almost understands what he is watching, and walks out of the theatre without quite admitting it. The audience will do the same.

Player 1

THE MAN WITH ALL THE HATS

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. **He is in his forties** — old enough to have been promised a career, young enough that the failure still stings fresh, and exactly the wrong age to begin again. The dominant register is the Leading Man, and the Leading Man is the spine of his comedy: vain, faded, defensive, and entirely English in a city that has not given him the career he was promised. He came to Lausanne fifteen years ago, in his late twenties, understanding it was a stepping stone to Paris. Paris did not happen. London does not call. He plays the cards he was dealt — Leading Man at the Village Players, every season — and an increasing share of voice-over work for cantonal radio he does not mention.

His vanity is real. So is the affection beneath it. The vanity shows in the body — the way he holds himself before he speaks, the small grooming gesture before a line he believes is his, the lift of the chin when he thinks the room is watching. He name-drops productions from years ago that nobody remembers, and one production he was *nearly* cast in, which was almost the West End. He says *I have a reputation in this canton*, and on his good days he believes it; on his bad days he says it anyway. He speaks an Anglo English that he thinks of as classical and the audience reads as *English*. He cannot quite remember whether he prefers Pinter or Coward, but he has opinions about both.

The arc to score across the production: he begins Act One in command — the Leading Man with the loudest objection to the cook's cap, the strut, the offence. He spends Act Two being asked to do the old-gallant routine he has spent his career rehearsing, and being laughed at for it by a woman half his age who has actually been through the room he is faking. By Act Three he is one of the Players who would, if he could, go home quietly. The vanity itself never breaks — that is the point — but the audience must see it has stopped protecting him.

He plays five roles, but always as himself. The Leading Man simply puts on different hats. His Door-keeper still has his self-importance. His Machinist still has his opinions. His L'Ingénue is the joke he doesn't quite get is on him. The audience should never feel they are watching five characters; they are watching one man performing his way through five functions, and the same vanity is at the centre of each. He is, in his own estimation, the senior actor in the company — the unofficial spokesman, the one who has the first opinion on every issue, the one whose objections (he believes) speak for everyone. The company tolerates him because he is, occasionally, right.

So the secondary roles are not transformations — they are this man in five hats. The **Door-keeper** is the Leading Man pretending modesty: he lets the wrong six people in and immediately blames the door, the

morning, anything but his own judgement. The **Machinist** drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two and looks at it for a long second as if he might apologise to it on tape. **L'Ingénue** is the role he can least pretend to inhabit — half a beat, his real voice slips through, he's gone. The **Third Actor** is whoever the script needs and a chance for the senior actor to demonstrate range. Every transition must be visible — the change of bearing, the lift of the chin, the breath caught a half-beat too long — but underneath the costumes it must remain him. Lean into the Leading Man early. The other four are him with different lighting.

Player 2

THE DIVA AND THE PROPS

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. **About thirty-five — and the real working professional Player 1 only impersonates.** She is some years younger than him and a great deal better at the job: she has already played leads at the Lausanne houses — a Marivaux at the Vidy, a Beckett at the Pulloff they still talk about — and she has had drinks with everyone on the cantonal arts council at some point. She is not the eldest in the room; she is the one who actually books the work, season after season, while the older man beside her recites the career he meant to have. She does not need to say so. Her authority is in her shoulders, not her years.

She plays four roles, but always as herself, just as Player 1 does. Her **Leading Lady** is weary, slightly offended, deeply professional — the diva is real, the diva is earned, and at thirty-five she is already a little tired of having to be one. Her **Property Man** is the same woman in a different posture: efficient, no-nonsense, vaguely irritated, the patience the director has personally exhausted. She *chose* to do the props this season because the company could not afford a real Property Man and she was not going to let the show open without a folding screen. She is not ashamed of either register. Both are work. Both are paid in francs.

The transition between the two is in the bearing — chest lifted and chin raised for the Leading Lady, shoulders down and weight forward for the Property Man — and the audience should come to read the flip without any prop signalling it.

The arc to score: in Act One she watches the Six arrive with the patience of a woman who has seen weirder things in this profession. In Act Two the Father asks the actresses for their hats and she gives him hers without a word; then she climbs onto the upper platform to play the Step-Daughter, and is laughed at by a much younger woman who has actually been through the room she is being asked to fake. That laugh is the wound. By the time she says *I have been made a fool of by better*, she means it. She has been. By Act Three she would like to be at home with the cat. She is one of the Players who, by then, knows the play has run away from them and is being polite about it. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory — and so is the bar afterwards.

Player 3

THE YOUNGEST, AND THE CURIOUS ONE

Player 3 may be played by a young man or a young woman — the part is written for either. These notes use *they*; the director should settle on the pronoun that fits the actor cast, and adjust the few stage directions that carry it.

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. **In their early twenties — the youngest in the company by a good ten years.** First proper season at the Village Players, after a few small parts last year and a drama school in Geneva that they still mention when they are nervous. They are not yet sure whether they are an actor or a person who is currently acting. **They are also, without question, the happiest person in the building** — they still cannot quite believe they are being paid (a little) to spend their evenings inside a theatre — and they do a bit of everything: prompt from the box, read the small parts, help strike the set, run for the props nobody else will fetch. No job is beneath them, because all of it is theatre, and theatre is the thing they love. The audience reads their age the moment they enter: the body is younger, the listening is sharper, the eyes track the older two to learn what one does.

Their dominant register is *curious*. Where Player 1 has opinions and Player 2 has shoulders, Player 3 has questions. When the Six arrive they are the first to take them seriously — not because they believe the Father's philosophy, but because they have never seen a rehearsal interrupted in this way and they want to know what happens. They lean forward. They nod. They catch themselves nodding and try to stop. The other two notice; they colour. **The notebook is their tell:** they write everything down — lines, phrases, things they do not yet understand but suspect they are meant to keep — and the moment they stop writing is the moment the play has stopped being a curiosity and become something they would rather not have on record.

The arc to score: in Act One they are enthralled by the strangers and slightly embarrassed by their own enthrallment — the one Player who keeps watching when the others are still cracking wise. In Act Two they stop finding it funny; the pencil goes still. By Act Three they are the Player who has understood the play the company has stumbled into — the conscience who asks whether someone should stop this, and waits, and is not answered. Their face is the audience's mirror at every horror in the second half.

They play four roles. The **Juvenile Lead** is eager and slightly ridiculous — they have been told they have "stage presence" and have heard it as *promise*. The **Prompter** is them in a wooden box, frowning at the draught and the shorthand, pleased to be useful, faintly aware they are too young for the role and trying to compensate with seriousness. **An Actor** and the **Fifth Actor** are functions: someone has to read a line. They read them clean, no pretension, and look to Player 2 to check they did it right.

The casting note for the audition room: the actor — of any gender — must be young enough that the age difference reads from the back row, and a sharp enough listener that the company's whole second half can be tracked on their face. The audience must believe both that this is the youngest person in the room and that they are the one who understands soonest what the company has stumbled into. That is the role's range.

Madame Pace

THE BUSINESSWOMAN OF SHAME

Madame Pace is the seventh Character — and now her own performer. Pirandello marks her as the one figure not among the original Six, conjured onto the stage by its very arrangement: the hats on the pegs, the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), the folding screen. In this edition she is no longer doubled by one of the Players; a single actor carries her and nothing else, so that when the door upstage opens and she walks through it, the audience meets a person who was not in the room a moment ago and cannot say how she got there. That is the Pirandellian trick, restored: not an actor stepping into a costume in view of the house, but an apparition who simply *is* there.

She is an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. She is a businesswoman of shame: elegant, practical, smiling, and morally rotten. She does not shout — her danger comes from being calm. Play the comedy of her accent at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit. The audience laughs when she enters, and is disgusted with itself for having laughed by the time she leaves — that double sensation is the point of her. **Do not let her become an accent joke.** The accent is the entrance. The bookkeeping is the body of her.

The casting note for the audition room: this is the production's most theatrically demanding role, and it lives entirely in one scene. Cast for an actor with the physical control to land both ends of her — comic on arrival, chilling on exit — and the discipline to hold a smile that never drops while everything underneath it turns. The wig and the silver chain do half the work; the body and the voice do the rest. The accent must be performed with no protective irony. The audience must believe both that she is the funniest thing they have seen all night and that she is the most frightening. That is the role's range.

The Comedy is without acts or scenes. The performance is interrupted once, without the curtain being lowered, when the manager and the chief characters withdraw to arrange the scenario. A second interruption of the action takes place when, by mistake, the stage hands let the curtain down.

A NOTE ON THIS PRODUCTION

How this version is to be performed

This edition adapts Pirandello's play for a chamber staging of **nine live performers and two stage objects, across three stripped, sculptural settings.**

The Storer translation is the spine — lightly modernised, and trimmed for pace in this acting edition (a handful of the longer speeches are compressed, never gutted; every essential idea and story beat is kept). The chief rearrangement is the *who-plays-what*. There is no projection, no video, no screen: the Boy and the Child are objects on the stage from the moment the Six walk on, and the audience reads them as children because the company does.

NINE BODIES ON THE STAGE

Four play the family. The Father, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, and The Son are each played by a single actor in flesh, and each remains so for the whole play.

One plays The Manager. Pirandello's director-figure stays exactly as written.

Three play everyone else. The dozen lesser company roles of the Village Players — Leading Man, Leading Lady, Juvenile Lead, L'Ingénue, Property Man, Prompter, Door-keeper, Machinist, the Second Lady Lead, the Third / Fourth / Fifth Actors — are divided among three Players.

One plays Madame Pace. She is a Character rather than a company actor — the seventh figure, conjured onto the upper level in Act Two by the magic of the stage — and in this edition she is carried by a single performer of her own, no longer doubled by one of the Players. The dedicated actor lets the conjuring trick stand as Pirandello wrote it: a woman who was not in the room walks through the upstage door, and no one can say how.

TWO OBJECTS IN PLACE OF TWO BODIES

The Boy (fourteen) and the Child (about four) — the silent youngest of the Six — are not played by live performers. They are present as two objects on the stage, and the script that follows refers to them by these names:

- **The Child-bundle.** A small wrapped bundle of white cloth — a swaddling, like an infant in a blanket — which the Step-Daughter carries, kisses, sets down, and lifts again. It never moves on its own. The other Characters hold it and speak to it as the Child.
- **The Boy-chair.** A black coat and a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a small leather satchel by the chair leg. It stands at the side of the stage from the moment the Six walk on, and is moved behind the fountain basin in Act Three. Where Pirandello's text has the Step-Daughter *seize* the Boy or *push* him forward, she handles the chair and the coat; where she takes a revolver from his pocket, she takes it from the coat hanging on the chair.

No performer is ever seen to play either child. The convention sets itself live, in the first thirty seconds, by what the company's hands do — and the audience reads the two objects as the children because everyone on stage treats them so. They are heavier than performers would be; every gesture toward them lands. **From here on, the script and these notes call them simply the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair — or, where the family speaks of them, the Child and the Boy.**

WHERE IT HAPPENS

The production is set in Lausanne, Switzerland — not the Rome that Pirandello half-implied in 1921, but a modern Swiss city of equal civility and equal cruelty. The theatre company on stage is the **Village Players**, a working repertory house in residence at Lausanne. Their season has been forced to include a play they did not choose, by a playwright they do not particularly trust. They are now in technical rehearsal for it on the morning we walk in. Six strangers will walk in too.

Madame Pace's atelier — the back room where the hundred francs changed hands — sits somewhere off the rue de Bourg, in a courtyard near Saint-François. Her shop sign reads *robes et manteaux*, as Pirandello's stage directions already require. She is Italian-Swiss, an immigrant who has built a small business of dressmaking and other less nameable commerce. Her speech is a foreigner's broken English, carried on a thick Italian-Swiss-and-French accent — ridiculous, grotesque,

instantly recognisable to anyone in the Lausanne audience who has been overcharged at any small shop run by a woman who knows more about them than they would like.

The relocation is a directorial choice, not a textual one — it rewrites none of Pirandello's dialogue. What changes is the room the play imagines itself inside — the air outside its windows, the language overheard from the street, the city the family fled from and the city they are now trapped inside.

A STRIPPED STAGE

The production refuses period-theatre clutter. Each act has a single defining visual element, and almost nothing else. The aesthetic is sculptural, not decorative. Light, levels, and one bold object per act do the rest.

- **Act One — Chairs.** A bare stage with a circle of chairs. Working lights. No flats, no furniture, no props beyond the chairs themselves. The company sits in their chairs and performs boredom; the Manager has his own chair, set apart. When the Six walk on, the Door-keeper sets the Boy-chair at the edge of the stage and the Step-Daughter carries on the Child-bundle; the four live Characters join the company in chairs of their own.
- **Act Two — Two floors.** The stage is built on two levels. The upper platform is the rehearsal stage — where the family's drama is played, where Madame Pace is summoned, where the white parlour is briefly fitted up. The lower floor is everything else: the space outside the performance, where the actors watch, where the Six wait between scenes, where the technical apparatus of the house lives. The vertical separation is the act's whole point. Performing is up. Watching is down. The line between them is the edge of the upper platform, and the play crosses it constantly.
- **Act Three — The fountain.** A single short basin in the middle of an otherwise bare stage. Stone or concrete. The walls of the basin are high enough that nobody — neither audience nor live actors — can see inside it. When the Step-Daughter bends over the fountain to hide the Child, the basin itself does the hiding. The garden around it is empty. No trees, no flats, no painted cardboard. One basin, four live Characters, the Boy-chair at the side, the empty stage.

NO PROJECTION, NO SCREEN

This production uses no projection — no rear-wall video, no recorded voice, no held image, no screen anywhere in the play. Every effect is carried live, by bodies, objects, and light:

- **The arrival of the Six.** Set live — by the way the Door-keeper places the Boy-chair and the Step-Daughter holds the Child-bundle. No video.
- **The Step-Daughter's Act Two monologue.** She speaks it live, alone, to the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The shower-light falls on her. The pianist plays the Satie. When the script reaches the moment of the revolver, she handles the Boy-chair by the sleeve and pulls the revolver from its pocket. The audience does not need a screen: the speech is to the Child-bundle and the chair, and the actor's care for both does the work.
- **The fountain image.** The Step-Daughter bends over the Child-bundle inside the basin while the Son narrates from upstage. As the Son speaks of the Boy who stood and watched, the stage lights drop slowly until only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare hanging bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin for as long as the silence will hold it. Then full blackout. Then, out of the dark, the gunshot from behind the basin.

The rear wall stays dark for the whole production. The children are objects on the stage from the first moment, and the audience reads them as children because every body around them treats them as such.

HOW THE THREE PLAYERS DIVIDE THE COMPANY

The division is built on a single rule: *no Player should ever speak as one of their roles in direct dialogue with another of their own roles*. Every adjacency in the play was checked against this rule.

PLAYER 1	<i>Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor</i>
PLAYER 2	<i>Leading Lady · Property Man · Second Lady Lead (silent) · Fourth Actor</i>
PLAYER 3	<i>Juvenile Lead · Prompter · An Actor · Fifth Actor</i>

The graph admits one unavoidable corner: in the beat of Act Two where Madame Pace materialises, Player 1 must speak briefly as L'Ingénue and as Leading Man within a few moments. The director should handle this with a wig signifier or a brief turn of the body. All other transitions are clean.

Chorus moments — what Pirandello marks as *The Actors, Some Actresses, Actors and Actresses* — are assigned to named players in this text rather than left vague:

Player 1, Player 2 & Player 3 when all three speak together, and a named pair (for example **Player 1 & Player 2**) when only two do.

HOW SPEAKER TAGS LOOK IN THIS EDITION

The three company actors are named in the script only as **Player 1**, **Player 2**, and **Player 3** — never by the particular role they are playing in the moment. The speaker tag reads simply:

Player 1. *Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?*

Which of their assigned roles a Player is inhabiting at any point is set by the division above and by the scene around them. The four family Characters, The Manager, and Madame Pace keep their proper names, because each is played by a single performer throughout.

LIGHT AND SOUND

The production's emotional weather is carried by light and music as much as by performance. Three rules across the three acts: in Act One the room is lit in three colours, one per part. In Act Two the lighting acquires an architectural object — the shower — and the sound acquires a body, a pianist on stage. In Act Three almost all the light is gone; the fountain lights itself; the music has retreated to a single sustained note.

ACT ONE — THREE COLOURS, ONE RADIO

- **Part I (The Rehearsal).** *White working lights.* The room is cold-white, fluorescent, unflattering — the light of an actual morning rehearsal. From the wings, a small radio plays quietly: an old French chanson, slightly crackling, the sound of any Lausanne theatre at nine in the morning. Suggested track: Aznavour's *La Bohème* at low volume, or a scratchy Édith Piaf record (*La Vie en rose*, *Sous le ciel de Paris*). It should feel domestic, ambient, almost cute — like the company has forgotten to turn it off.
- **Part II (The Family Arrives).** *Amber / honey gold.* The moment the Door-keeper speaks, the radio in the wings cuts off and the white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello already specifies for the Six. The four live Characters walk on inside that warmth; the Step-Daughter is already carrying the Child-bundle, the Door-keeper carries the Boy-chair in and sets it at the edge. The only live music in this part is the Step-Daughter's own

— she sings and dances *Valentine* (Maurice Chevalier's 1925 music-hall number), chosen as period café-concert material: cheeky, dated on purpose, a young woman weaponising her own impudence. Otherwise the warmth is the score.

- **Part III (The Bargain).** *Deep red / crimson.* The light turns slowly, almost imperceptibly, from amber to red across the part — beginning the moment the Step-Daughter says *hundred francs*. By the end of the act it is a low, blood-coloured wash. No music. The silence under the red is the texture; the cue for Act Two is the absence of sound.

ACT TWO — THE PIANIST AND THE SHOWER

A small upright piano sits stage-right on the lower floor, visible to the audience throughout the act. The pianist is a credited performer — fourth Player, in effect — and plays from where they sit, in dialogue with the action above them on the upper platform. They do not speak.

The *shower* is a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source, narrow enough that a single performer can stand inside it and a second performer cannot. It is used three times in Act Two and not elsewhere in the production.

- **Part I — the Step-Daughter alone in the shower.** The Step-Daughter speaks her opening monologue live, alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair beside her. The *shower* falls on her only — the rest of the stage is dark. The pianist plays Satie's *Gymnopédie No. 1* — slow, simple, repeated, child-haunted — once through across the monologue. The piano ends with her last line, when she has set the Child-bundle down and the revolver back into the coat.
- **Part II — Madame Pace's aria.** As Madame Pace materialises on the upper platform, she steps into the *shower*. The pianist begins a slow Weimar-shop vamp — a sleazy, comic-cabaret tune. Suggested: Kurt Weill's *Bilbao Song* at half tempo, or a vamp on Mistinguett's *Mon Homme*. The piano plays continuously through her aria — through the broken-French dialect, through *he clean, he polite, he pay cash*, through everything — until the Mother says *You old devil. You murderess*. The piano dies on that line, mid-bar. The silence is the wound.
- **Part III — the doubled scene and the Mother's cry.** The pianist comes back cautiously when the Leading Lady and Leading Man take the platform — picking out fragments of the Madame Pace vamp, but in tatters, as if rehearsing the same tune badly. The *shower* falls on the Mother during her keystone line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* — the only light in the room is the column she stands in. The piano cuts out the moment her cry begins, and does not return. The accidental curtain falls in silence, except for a single piano chord, held, as the lights go.

ACT THREE — DARK, THE FOUNTAIN LIT, ONE HANGING BULB

The stage is dark. The fountain basin is lit from inside — pale blue, faintly rippling, the colour of water in a public garden at night. Performers are in silhouette around it. There is one other light source on the stage: *a single bare bulb hanging above the Manager's table*, practical, ugly, the working light of a director who has stopped trying to make this beautiful. The bulb swings, very slightly, throughout the act.

- **Part I (The Trap).** Background: a single sustained cello drone, very low — one note, varying barely. The audience should not consciously hear it; they should feel that the room has a pulse. Suggested: a sustained C in the cello's lowest register, or a low organ pedal-tone. The drone continues through the entire philosophical stretch and dies as the Step-Daughter cuts him with *His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.*
- **Part II (The Refusal).** Silence. No drone, no piano, no underscoring. The Son's refusal happens in actual silence — only footsteps and breath. One exception: when the Father grabs the Son's arm at *You can force him, sir*, a single sharp note sounds from the piano (offstage now, or recorded — the pianist's chair on the lower floor is empty in this act). Like a slap. Then silence again.
- **Part III (The Fountain).** The sound of water — the fountain itself, live if possible, recorded if necessary — comes in at the start of the part and stays. Slightly louder as the Step-Daughter approaches the basin. The gunshot is real, in real silence — the water sound briefly stops with it. After the closing line — *To hell with it all.* — and the Manager's exit, the first phrase of Arvo Pärt's *Spiegel im Spiegel* opens, about ten seconds, and the lights go.

The light and sound design should be felt, not heard. The audience does not need to know they are being scored. The cues are above; the rest is taste.

AUDITION BLOCK — 2 / 5 / 10 JUNE 2026 · 18:00 – 21:00 · SSA LAUSANNE

Three audition sessions before the Thursday table-work block begins. Each runs **18:00 to 21:00** at SSA Lausanne. The director uses the *Audition Checklist*; auditioners read sides from the *Audition Pack*. Nine cast tracks to fill: Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son, Manager, Players 1 / 2 / 3, and Madame Pace.

- **Tuesday 2 June 2026 — Open auditions, session 1.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00.

- **Friday 5 June 2026 — Open auditions, session 2.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. Additional slot for auditioners who could not attend on the Tuesday.
- **Wednesday 10 June 2026 — Callbacks and final casting.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. Callbacks for borderline decisions; the confirmed cast is announced at the end of the evening.

TABLE - WORK BLOCK — THURSDAYS, 18 JUNE – 30 JULY 2026 ·
18:00 – 21:00 · SSA LAUSANNE

Seven Thursday evenings at SSA Lausanne, every Thursday from 18 June through 30 July 2026. Each session runs from **18:00 to 21:00** in the room. By the end of it, the play has been read in full, the part-notes have been walked through, and every actor has a working understanding of the four-stage arcs and signature physical readings they will commit to. The heavier staging block begins in August (see the staging block below).

The plan below names what each session is for. Sessions may run longer or shorter inside the 18:00 – 21:00 window depending on attendance, energy, and what the room asks for on the night. The architecture is what matters: each Thursday lays one course of the wall the August block will then build on.

- **Thursday 18 June 2026 — First table reading.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. The full confirmed company gathers for the first time. Round-table introductions, distribution of the Director's Copy and the Actor Rehearsal Script. The full play read out loud by the company in order, around a table. No staging. No light. No music. Just hearing the play as a company for the first time.
- **Thursday 25 June 2026 — Production walk-through.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. Walk-through of the production concept (nine performers, two stage objects, three stripped settings — no projection, no screen). The Boy-chair (Boy) and the Child-bundle (Child) introduced as physical conventions. The Step-Daughter and the Mother are asked to keep the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair by them throughout, even at the table, so the company sees the conventions from this session forward.
- **Thursday 2 July 2026 — Act One table work.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. Per-part discussion using the Act One part-notes. The Father's four-stage arc and the autobiographical-as-metaphysical reading. The Step-Daughter's exposure (the hundred francs, Madame Pace's atelier, the room she will not let be made beautiful). The Mother's veil and her three silences. The Players' Lausanne register — local, modern, amateur-in-the-best-sense. Light & Sound concept for Act One walked through: white → amber → red across the three parts, the radio in the wings.

- **Thursday 9 July 2026 — Act Two table work.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. The Step-Daughter's solo monologue — staged live with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair, in the shower light, with Satie underneath. Madame Pace's work begins with her own performer: the dialect, the bearing, the bookkeeping aria. The pianist score introduced (Satie's *Gymnopédie No. 1*, Weill's *Bilbao Song*, Mistinguett's *Mon Homme*); pianist confirmed for the production.
- **Thursday 16 July 2026 — Act Three table work.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. The philosophical debate of Part I — the Father's four-stage arc on his feet for the first time, with the Step-Daughter's three cuts placed and timed. The Son's refusal in Part II — the mirror speech, the closing exchange. The Manager's pivot moment when he picks up the Boy-chair himself. Light & Sound for Act Three: dark stage, fountain lit from inside, the single hanging bulb, the cello drone, the Pärt at the curtain.
- **Thursday 23 July 2026 — Light & Sound walk-through, difficult scenes.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. The full cue list walked through with the stage manager and the company — every light, every sound, every piano cue. The hardest scenes returned to: the Madame Pace aria, the shop-scene replay, the fountain. Notes on what the production requires of every body in those scenes.
- **Thursday 30 July 2026 — Full read-through with cues.** SSA Lausanne, 18:00 – 21:00. End-to-end read of the play with light and sound cues called aloud by the stage manager. Notes session afterwards: what landed, what didn't, what each actor still needs to find before August. Confirmation of the staging-block calendar (20 August – 1 November 2026; the first two weeks of August are the summer break). The cast leaves with the August schedule and homework: memorise your part; sit with the part-notes; arrive on 20 August ready to be on your feet.

The principle across the seven Thursdays: **table work, not blocking**. No staging is set in this phase. What gets set is the company's shared understanding of the play and the cues. August is when bodies start to move.

STAGING BLOCK — 20 AUGUST – 1 NOVEMBER 2026 · WEEKLY THURSDAYS · SSA LAUSANNE

The company takes the first two weeks of August as a **summer break — there is no rehearsal on 5 or 13 August 2026**. The staging block proper runs from **Thursday 20 August 2026** through **Sunday 1 November 2026**. Primary sessions remain Thursdays 18:00 – 21:00 at SSA Lausanne, with additional weekend sessions added where the room requires it (intensive blocking, full run-throughs, technical and dress rehearsals). Performances open in late autumn 2026, after the staging block closes.

- **5 & 13 August 2026 — Summer break.** No rehearsal. Memorisation, dramaturgical rest, technical prep. The company returns on 20 August.
- **Thursday 20 August 2026 — Re-orientation and Act One blocking.** The company returns from the break. Floor markings begin. Act One blocked across all three parts — Part I (the rehearsal), Part II (the family's arrival), Part III (the bargain): the slow drift to deep red, the Step-Daughter's *hundred francs*, the act-end silence.
- **Thursday 27 August 2026 — Act One run; Act Two Parts I & II.** First end-to-end run of Act One on its feet. Act Two Part I introduced (the Step-Daughter's live monologue in the shower light, the pianist's first entrance) and Part II, Madame Pace's aria: her performer brought to performance level, the pianist's Weimar vamp, the shower light called in.
- **Thursday 3 September 2026 — Act Two Part III: the doubled scene and the Mother's cry.** The shop-scene replay between Leading Lady and Leading Man. The Mother's keystone line and the shower falling on her.
- **Thursday 10 September 2026 — Act Three Part I: the argument over reality.** The Father's four-stage arc on his feet. The Step-Daughter's three cuts. The cello drone underneath.
- **Thursday 17 September 2026 — Act Three Part II: the Son's refusal.** Mirror speech, closing exchange, the silence that does the work.
- **Thursday 24 September 2026 — Act Three Part III: the fountain.** The basin lit from inside, the gunshot in real silence, the Part at the curtain.
- **Thursday 1 October 2026 — First full run-through.** End-to-end run of the play. No stopping for notes inside the run; full notes session afterwards.
- **Thursday 8 October 2026 — Second full run-through, scene refinement.** Tighten what the first run revealed.
- **Thursday 15 October 2026 — Third run-through, costume integration.** Costumes introduced for the principals. Last rehearsal at SSA Lausanne before the move to the performance venue.
- **Thursday 22 October 2026 — Technical rehearsal.** Full cue call with the operators, in the performance venue. Light operator, sound operator, pianist all in their positions for the first time.
- **Thursday 29 October 2026 — Dress rehearsal.** Full costume, full cues, played as if for an audience. Notes for the next day are minimal.
- **Sunday 1 November 2026 — Final dress / preview.** The last session of the staging block. Whatever the production needs before opening — a final dress, a preview to a small invited audience, a last technical pass.

Performances open in late autumn 2026 — a short run of three or four performances. Dates and venue to be announced.

The Assistant Director is the director's second pair of eyes and the director's voice when the director is not in the room. In an amateur company this is most often a colleague from the Village Players, or a friend with directing experience who has been brought in to support the production. They do not direct; they assist directing. Where they are present, the director can focus on the moment in front of them while the rest of the production continues to move forward.

Their work falls into six areas. The list below is complete; nothing here is optional once the role has been accepted.

- **In rehearsal, with the director.** They take notes throughout each session. They hold the script. They track blocking changes as they are made. They watch for moments the director may have missed because the director was working with a different actor at the same time. They watch for tonal drift, energy drops, scenes running long, off-message comedy. They quietly flag the director when something is slipping. At the end of each session they debrief with the director: what worked, what did not, what to come back to next week. They keep a running list of unresolved questions so nothing gets quietly dropped.
- **With the cast, between scenes and between sessions.** They run sub-rehearsals when the director is occupied elsewhere — a Player working on the Madame Pace dialect, say, while the director works the Step-Daughter and Mother on the "It's taking place now" beat. They brief actors who missed the previous session: what was decided, what was tried, what changed. They hold line readings when the director is not in the room. They are available between rehearsals for actor questions the director does not need to answer personally.
- **In technical and dress rehearsals.** A second pair of eyes from the house — watching the play as the audience will see it, with the light and sound cues running. They flag anything that does not read: a stage direction that is not landing, a cue arriving too early or too late, a sightline blocked, an actor not lit, the pianist's tempo off, the shower-light missing its mark. The director cannot direct and watch the play at the same time; the Assistant Director makes the second pair of eyes possible.
- **During the run of performances.** They watch each performance from the house. They take notes — what landed, what is drifting, what each actor needs to know before the next show. They feed the notes to the director the next morning. They handle the day-to-day communication with the cast so the director can think about the play.
- **Between rehearsals — communication.** They are the director's voice when the director is not on call. Email and message follow-up with cast. Coordination with the Stage Manager on scheduling, room changes, missing material. Distribution of any revised pages. Reading the

room for energy and morale across the production; flagging anything significant to the director directly.

What the Assistant Director does *not* do: cast the production (the director casts); block the show (the director blocks); give acting notes directly to actors during a director's session (notes go through the director).

THE STAGE MANAGER — WHAT THEY DO

The Stage Manager is the production's spine. Where the Director shapes the play and the Assistant Director extends the director's reach, the Stage Manager makes the production run. Without an effective Stage Manager an amateur company cannot reliably open a show; with one, every other role on the production gets to focus on the work in front of them.

Their work runs from before the first rehearsal until the strike. Six areas. The list below is complete.

- **Before the first rehearsal.** Room bookings at SSA Lausanne for the three audition sessions (Tue 2, Fri 5, Wed 10 June), the seven Thursday table-work evenings (18 June – 30 July), and the staging block (20 August – 1 November; 5 & 13 August are the summer break, no rehearsal). The full rehearsal calendar communicated to the cast — email, calendar invite, and a shared document everyone can see. Distribution: every cast member receives the Director's Copy, the Actor Rehearsal Script, and the calendar before the first read-through. Logistics: keys, room access, working lights, water, any administrative paperwork the company needs. Initial contact with the pianist and (where applicable) the light and sound operators.
- **During the seven-Thursday block.** Attendance: tracking who is in, who is out, who is late, who is missing entirely. The rehearsal log: a written record of every session — what was worked, what changed, what needs revisiting next week. Prompt book maintenance from day one: every blocking note (when blocking starts), every line change, every cue placement goes into the master script. Continuity: any cast member who missed last week is briefed by the Stage Manager on what was decided so the director does not have to spend the next session catching them up. Communication: the director and the cast both go through the Stage Manager for scheduling and logistical questions.
- **During the August–November weekly rehearsals.** Floor markings: blocking marks taped on the rehearsal-room floor as staging is set, so actors can find their positions reliably. Props inventory tracked from this point on: the white bundle (the Child), the wooden chair with the black coat folded over its back, the schoolboy's cap, the leather satchel at the chair leg, the pale-blue envelope, the little mahogany table, the folding screen, the hat-rack, the hats given by the

actresses to the Father, the cook's cap and apron from *Mixing It Up*, Madame Pace's long silver chain with scissors, the prop revolver. Every item sourced, labelled, stored, and accounted for at every rehearsal. Costume continuity tracked: the Mother's heavy widow's veil, the Step-Daughter's mourning, the Father's morning coat, Madame Pace's wig and bleach-blonde puff and black silk, the Players' working-rehearsal clothes. Cue building: as the light and sound score is rehearsed into the room, every cue is written into the prompt book, walked through with the operators, and timed.

- **Technical and dress rehearsals.** Cue calling: the Stage Manager calls every cue in the play — light, sound, curtain, the pianist's entrances and exits, the shower-light beats, the fountain water, the gunshot, the Pärt at the closing. The prompt book is now the master document for the show. Technical coordination: with the lighting operator, the sound operator, the pianist. Dress: full run with costumes, props, cues; notes taken in real time; problems triaged before opening night.
- **During the performance run.** Calling the show from the prompt book — every cue, every scene change, every intermission, every curtain. Backstage management: actor entrances and exits, handling any onstage problem in real time (a missed entrance, a prop misplaced, a cue that did not fire, an actor who is unwell), holding the show only if absolutely necessary. Health and safety on stage throughout. Liaison with front-of-house if there is no separate House Manager. Locking the venue at the end of each night.
- **After the run.** Strike: returning the venue to its starting condition, returning hired equipment, returning costumes, returning the keys. Archive: filing the final prompt book, the rehearsal log, the cue list, the props list. Post-mortem with the director: what worked technically, what would be done differently on the next production, what the company learned about its own room.

What the Stage Manager does *not* do: direct (the director directs); give acting notes (those go through the director or the Assistant Director); change the script (changes go through the director and are entered into the prompt book only after the director has signed off); negotiate scheduling with individual cast members without coordinating first with the Assistant Director.

THE TWO OF THEM WORKING TOGETHER

The Assistant Director and the Stage Manager are different roles with overlapping territory. In a small company they often work as a pair. Communication between them is daily during the rehearsal block: who is in the room, what changed, what props are still missing, what each actor needs before next session. The director should not be the message router between them; they speak directly to one another, and they tell the director the outcome — not the other way around.

Where their responsibilities overlap — cast scheduling communication, calendar logistics, the prompt book, room access — they decide between themselves who handles what for each given week, and they tell the director. The principle: the director should have to think about the play. Everything else flows through these two roles.

— *K. J.*

ACT THE FIRST

I

. . .

The Family — a story walks in off the street and asks to be staged

PART I OF ACT ONE

The Rehearsal

The curtain rises on a bare stage with a circle of chairs and nothing else. Working lights. No furniture, no flats, no props. The Manager arrives at his theatre to a half-rehearsed company seated in those chairs in various postures of professional boredom. The play they are meant to rehearse this morning is one of Pirandello's own — *Mixing It Up* — which the Manager believes is unstageable, and which his contract has forced him to stage anyway. He bickers with the Leading Man about being asked to wear a cook's cap in a serious play. He insults the playwright. He insults the script. He insults the conditions under which any working theatre is forced to operate. None of this surprises his actors, who have heard it before; some are tying their shoes, some are reading the paper, none is rehearsing.

The Prompter takes his place in the box, complaining about the draught. The Property Man enters with furniture for an entirely different scene than the one being rehearsed. The Door-keeper waits at the back of the house with a stack of unread letters. The apparatus of the working theatre — irritation, vanity, exhaustion, the small professional dignities — is performing itself, for nobody it knows is watching.

The audience watches all of this comedy and does not yet know it is watching a comedy. The play has not announced itself. We are inside the engine room of the production, not the production. There is no Pirandello here yet, except in the contract burning quietly on the table.

Playing note: play Part I dry and worn — the company is tired, not performing wit; keep the comedy deadpan, and add nothing beyond what is written.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	14 speeches · 243 words
<i>Player 2</i>	7 speeches · 54 words
<i>Player 1</i>	8 speeches · 68 words
<i>Player 3</i>	4 speeches · 66 words
Total	33 speeches · 431 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

— The Manager is the engine of this part. Comic register must be committed — full anti-Pirandello rant, no protective irony.

- Player 1's Leading Man (the cook's-cap argument) is the largest single comic vehicle here. Play the vanity at full pitch.
- The audience should be laughing within three minutes. Pacing is everything; do not slow down for jokes you trust.
- Player 1 is doing three roles in quick succession (Leading Man, L'Ingénue, Door-keeper). Rehearse the transitions until they are physical reflex.
- The Property Man and Door-keeper are small comic anchors. Give them their beats.
- No metaphysics. None. Foreshadowing is a temptation that kills the rest of the evening.
- Work-lights stay up the whole part. Atmospheric lighting changes do not begin until the Six enter.

***T**he spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.*

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The **ACTORS** and **ACTRESSES** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **PROMPTER** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **PLAYERS**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **MANAGER** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **SECRETARY** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **PROMPTER** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

THE MANAGER *[throwing the morning's letters onto the table]*. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

PLAYER 2 *[she has been at work an hour; not looking up from her clipboard]*. It's all three, sir. The same envelope.

THE MANAGER *[looking round the half-lit room]*. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself, to no one in particular]*. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

THE MANAGER. Don't be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can't afford it. *[to the Property Man]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 *[a light comes down on to the stage]*. Half light. It's what's left.

THE MANAGER. Half light, half a company, half a budget. *[a beat]* We're ready for Pirandello. *[quietly, almost to himself]* God help us.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself]*. The public came back for the third act once.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up]*. For you?

PLAYER 1. During me. There's a difference.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the "book"]*. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down]*. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

PLAYER 2. With what, sir? Hope? *[a beat]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the "book"]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the "book"]*

PLAYER 1. But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

PLAYER 1 *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I'd sooner resign.

PLAYER 2. He resigns every Tuesday.

PLAYER 1 *[settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes — in, in.

PLAYER 3 *[pausing at the box, half to himself]*. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

THE MANAGER. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The DOOR-KEEPER enters from the stage door carrying the BOY-CHAIR — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live CHARACTERS — FATHER, MOTHER, STEP-DAUGHTER, SON — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The STEP-DAUGHTER is already carrying the CHILD-BUNDLE.

A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

He who is known as THE FATHER is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.

THE MOTHER seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.

*THE SON (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for THE FATHER, supercilious and indifferent to THE MOTHER.
He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

The Interruption

Six figures arrive. The white working lights soften to amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — walk in behind him, the Step-Daughter already carrying the Child-bundle.

The Father asks for an author. The Manager, baffled, asks what kind of madmen have walked in off the street. The Step-Daughter taunts the Father and exposes him: a hundred francs in a back-room of a dressmaker's shop, a pale blue envelope on a little table, a transaction this town has agreed not to talk about. The Mother nearly faints — the Father lifts her veil against her will. The Father explains his marriage, the secretary he sent his wife away with, the wet-nurse for his son in the country. Every confession is contradicted by the next mouth that opens. The family is laid bare, and laid bare twice.

The actors of the company, who began this part as bored professionals, slowly recede to the wings. They are now an audience to the spectacle that has walked into their rehearsal — and they keep reacting to it, dry and delighted, so the comedy never quite leaves the room. The lighting tightens on the family; the rehearsal room dims around them. But the laughs keep landing even as the family settles inside its own argument, with no author in sight. The comedy is what carries the audience into the drama, not what gets cleared away to make room for it.

Playing the scene. The Father is not explaining — he is trying to survive judgment: play the long speeches as panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture, and let his defence *escalate* rather than repeat — *I meant well → you misunderstand me → do not judge me by one moment → I am trapped by what she says I am.* The Step-Daughter is dangerous because she is precise: play the Madame Pace section forensically — evidence laid down, not anger screamed; cold revenge, not melodrama. And from Madame Pace onward the comedy must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable, never a punchline. If audience energy dips in the Father's loneliness/shame stretch, cut ten to fifteen per cent of it in the room. The Step-Daughter's long attack on the Son needs shape, not volume — attack, then wound, then disgust, then a turn of tenderness toward the Mother; never all screamed. And at the Father's plea of *pity* — that he kept the Mother not from boredom but from pity — he must sound like a man justifying something ugly, not playing it beautifully, or the Step-Daughter's anger leaves with it. The Step-Daughter is sharpest when wounded, not clever — find one or two moments where the cleverness drops and the hurt shows. And if any beat plays too clever in the room, cut five to ten per cent of it.

<i>Player 1</i>	9 speeches · 99 words
<i>The Manager</i>	31 speeches · 366 words
<i>The Father</i>	62 speeches · 1,735 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	42 speeches · 1,127 words
<i>Player 3</i>	2 speeches · 8 words
<i>Player 2</i>	6 speeches · 83 words
<i>Player 1, Player 2 & Player 3</i>	2 speeches · 11 words
<i>The Mother</i>	19 speeches · 264 words
<i>The Son</i>	12 speeches · 277 words
Total	185 speeches · 3,970 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The transition from comedy to interrogation is the most important pacing decision in Act One. It should be gradual, not signalled.
- The Step-Daughter is the engine of exposure, and the moral centre of the play. Her first taunts must land — not as flirtation, not as enjoyment, but as a young woman who has decided that the room will hear what happened to her, exactly, before anyone gets to make it into a scene.
- The Mother's faint is the temperature change. The actors-as-audience must visibly register it before the dialogue does.
- The Mother's veil is heavier than her face. Lowered, it does her listening for her — score the production around the single time it is lifted: the Father lifts it for her, against her will, in Act One. She never lifts it herself, not even at the fountain. Hold that line — the one exposure is his doing, never hers.
- **The Mother is the wound, not a voice in the argument.** The Father explains it, the Step-Daughter exposes it, the Son refuses it; she carries it. Keep her words few and let her body change the room. When she does speak — *He forced me to it; Not in front of her* — let a real silence open after it. Nobody jokes, nobody explains her away in the next breath. The Player who is about to relish the family's exposure should catch her face and lose the end of the sentence.
- **The Child-bundle is the Mother's, not only the Step-Daughter's.** Build the silent motif: when the men argue she checks it; when the shop is named she covers its ears; when the Son turns from her she holds it lower, as if it had grown heavier; and in Act Three she is the first to feel it gone from her arms, before anyone has said why. Her sorrow is active — she protects, hides, interrupts, refuses to look — never merely weeps.

- The Father's first long speeches should be played as urgent, not eloquent. He is a man fighting to be allowed to exist, not lecturing about it.
- **Keep this part moving — it is the longest in the play and the easiest to lose the room in.** Take the philosophy fast and overlapping; never let a speech sit while the next person waits politely. Let the Players' reactions and the Step-Daughter's cuts ride in close on the ends of lines. If the audience's attention can wander anywhere, it is here; play it as a quickening interrogation, not a debate.
- The Son does not move much in this part. His stillness must be a presence, not a passivity.
- Keep the Players visible as they recede to the wings. They are an onstage audience now — they should be doing what audiences do (watch, react, fail to look away).

SCORING PLAYER 1 ACROSS THE PRODUCTION

The Leading Man is a real type and a real person. The reading the actor must commit to: a once-promising Anglo actor who came to Lausanne thinking it was a stepping stone to Paris, never got there, and whose vanity is now a defense mechanism. The vanity lives in the body — in the bearing, the breath, the small grooming gestures before a line he believes is his, the lift of the chin when he thinks the room is watching.

- **The vanity is physical.** The audience reads it without props. The body arranges itself before a line he believes is his. The chin lifts. The breath catches. The bearing arrives. The first time it lands at *I have a reputation in this canton*. Then on his way back to the wings after he is cast as the Father. Then again — for the last time — when Madame Pace appears and he does not know what to do with himself. Each adjustment slightly less convincing than the last.
- **The shape of his arc.** Act One — in command, the loudest objection in the room. Act Two — asked to do the old-gallant routine he has spent his career rehearsing, and laughed at for it by a woman half his age who has actually been through the room he is faking. Act Three — one of the Players who would, if he could, go home quietly. The vanity itself never breaks; it just stops protecting him.
- **The keystone of the part.** *Neither am I. I am through with this scene.* Stage it as two steps toward the exit, then a small calculation crossing his face — he had nearly said *with this play, this company*. He cannot afford to walk off. He retreats into *this scene*. The audience reads the larger walk-out he swallowed. The swallowed self-correction is the role.
- **The five hats.** Lean into the Leading Man early. The Door-keeper, Machinist, L'Ingénue, and Third Actor are reliefs that show how thin the Leading Man's costume actually is. Every transition visible: the change of bearing, the lift of the chin, the breath caught a half-beat too long.
- **His register.** Anglo English he thinks of as classical and the audience reads as English. He name-drops productions nobody remembers. He has opinions on Coward and Pinter that contradict each

other depending on the week. He cannot say *Pirandello* three times without sounding put-upon by the fact.

- **What he never gets.** A single moment of being right. He is funny in Act One, mocked in Act Two, exhausted in Act Three, and at no point does the production hand him the dignity it hands the others. That absence is the whole of his comedy.

SCORING THE FATHER ACROSS THE PRODUCTION

The reading the actor must commit to: he is a well-educated middle-class man whose intellectual elegance is his shield against shame. His philosophy is not abstract — it is autobiographical, disguised as metaphysics. Every speech about reality or conscience is an attempt to argue himself back into being someone the room can listen to.

- **The body shows the shame.** No prop — the body itself. Heat at the brow, breath shortening, the small adjustments of a man who would prefer to be elsewhere. First appearance: the moment the Step-Daughter says *hundred francs* in Act One. It returns in the shop scene in Act Two; it is visible for the entire final stretch of Act Three. He composes himself when he is winning the argument. He loses composure when he is not.
- **The arc.** Act One: he arrives mellifluous, controlled, almost charming. He believes he can talk his way through this. Act Two: he must watch his shame literalised on a stage — twice. Act Three: control → injury → attack → horror, as scored in the Act Three Part I notes.
- **Mellifluous and violent.** His default voice is composed, precise, almost beautiful. It breaks the moment philosophy stops protecting him. The actor must find both — the eloquence that protects, and the violence underneath when the eloquence fails.
- **The Step-Daughter is his mirror.** She does not let him become the hero of the scene. Every time he reaches for a beautiful word, she names the literal fact behind it. Score the production so she is always able to reach him — and so he is always slightly unable to recover from being reached.
- **The "I'm frightfully sorry" lie.** In the shop scene replay, the Step-Daughter, almost to herself, corrects him: he did not say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." That is the most important small beat the actor will play across the whole production. The audience must see, in real time, that the Father has been lying — to the room, to himself, perhaps even to his author — about what he actually said that afternoon. Stage the small pause before the Father agrees: *Yes. He said "Oh."*
- **The shape of his performance in one sentence.** A wound becoming an argument. An argument becoming an attack. An attack becoming a confession. A confession becoming a prison. He should not end like a man who has won. He should end like a man who has just proved the walls of his own cell.

PLAYER 1 [*cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

PLAYER 1 [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the CHARACTERS.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

THE MANAGER [*half angry, half amazed*]. An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*stepping in front of the Father, taking the line*]. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

PLAYER 3 [*coming forward from the others*]. Oh — do you hear that?

PLAYER 1 [*stung; it lands because it is half true*]. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

THE FATHER [*to STEP-DAUGHTER*]. Yes, but if the author isn't here... [*To MANAGER.*] unless you would be willing...

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER [*stepping closer*]. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

THE MANAGER [*interpreting the rising anger of the COMPANY*]. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. [*The ACTORS, satisfied, applaud their MANAGER.*]

THE FATHER [*cutting across him*]. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. [*The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

THE MANAGER. But what do you mean? Before, you said...

THE FATHER. No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

THE MANAGER. Very well, — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

THE FATHER *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

PLAYER 1. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the PROMPTER'S box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards MANAGER, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

THE FATHER *[to the Manager]*. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

PLAYER 2 *[chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]*. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the MANAGER.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at him]*. His passion. Always the word *passion*.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him. *[Places a deliberate hand on the FATHER's shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

THE FATHER *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Valentine — bright, knowing, the smile a fraction too wide. Not a cabaret turn for its own sake but a provocation thrown by someone two months orphaned and lately for sale, daring the room to enjoy her. The audience should laugh, and then, a beat later, wish they had not.]*

*Elle avait de tout p'tits petons, Valentine, Valentine,
elle avait de tout p'tits tétons
que je tâtais à tâtons, ton-ton-tontaine,
elle avait un tout p'tit menton...*

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the FATHER in consternation.]* Is she mad?

PLAYER 1 *[to Player 2, won over]*. She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch*.

THE MOTHER *[to the MANAGER; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

At the word children, the MOTHER'S arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the COMPANY.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true, isn't it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

THE MOTHER. And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he *[Indicates the FATHER.]* made her do so.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor]*. He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the SON. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the MANAGER, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the FATHER.]* if it isn't true. Let him speak. You *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 *[to the COMPANY, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the MOTHER, and the end of the sentence does not arrive]*. What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

PLAYER 2 *[lower now]*. We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 *[quietly, the pencil not moving]*. For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen]*. Let's hear them out. Listen!

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. *[To the MANAGER.]* He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

THE SON *[without looking up]*. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the ACTORS.]*

THE SON *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER]*. This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

As the shop is named, the **MOTHER** draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room].* Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The STEP-DAUGHTER's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He does. [Indicating FATHER.]*

THE MANAGER *[the audience's confusion, on stage].* I don't understand this at all.

THE FATHER *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble].* Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. I say one thing, she hears another. I try to explain myself — and the explanation becomes another crime.

THE MOTHER *[not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room].* But you drove me away. *[A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.]*

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

THE MOTHER *[looking at the floor between them].* You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To MANAGER.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the LEADING LADY who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the LEADING MAN flirting with the STEP-DAUGHTER, comes forward and says to the MANAGER.]*

PLAYER 2. Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 1 *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing]*. Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

PLAYER 2. Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at LEADING MAN.]*

THE MANAGER *[to FATHER]*. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the MOTHER]*. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[pointing at him, no smile]*. As one can see.

THE FATHER *[quickly]*. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

PLAYER 1 *[shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]*. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*. Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[flat, into the room]*. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the cleverness drops — just the child she was]*. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

PLAYER 2 *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* She wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

THE SON *[turning his face away from the FATHER]*. Literature. Literature.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.]*, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee!

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. [*A small pointing gesture toward the MOTHER, immediately regretted.*] She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, [*the word arrives before he can stop it*] naturally, my interest dwindled. [*The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.*] But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts — not old enough to do without company, not young enough to seek it without shame. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. [*A beat. He has to swallow.*] One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

PLAYER 1 [*under his breath, to Player 3*]. I have several questions. None of them are polite.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

THE MANAGER. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to

my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time*. Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat*]. You walked into that room by yourself.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

THE SON [*the Father, cornered, has turned to his son — and the room's eyes follow. The Son keeps his hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — *you*! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can

therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

THE SON [*the one time the cold cracks*]. You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the MOTHER to the MANAGER.*] See, she's crying!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at the MOTHER*]. Like a fool.

THE FATHER [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.

The Bargain

The shop of Madame Pace is named for the first time. The hundred francs. The pale blue envelope. The Father offers his great speech on the many-sided conscience: we are not one self but many, and to be caught in one moment is to be falsified by it. The Manager, who began this part still believing he was being held hostage by lunatics, begins instead to think there is a play in this — perhaps even one his contract should be wishing for. The bargain begins to be struck.

The Step-Daughter is sharp and unrelenting; every time the Father reaches for a beautiful word, she puts the literal fact next to it. The Father is in mid-flight. The Son is cold; he announces, without much ceremony, that he does not come into this drama, and that any attempt to make him come into it will fail. The Father describes how the drama ends — the death of the Child by the fountain, the tragedy of the Boy behind the trees, the flight of the Step-Daughter into the night. He describes it not as memory but as fact, already written, already inside him.

The Manager exits to his office with the Characters to organise the rehearsal. The Players are left on stage in a small chorus of bewilderment — the Door-keeper protesting he only let them in, the Property Man muttering that first the script made no sense and now the audience walks in off the street, the Prompter asking, in shorthand, in shorthand? The curtain falls on a theatre that has not yet decided whether it has been broken into or rescued.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	12 speeches · 173 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	2 speeches · 19 words
<i>The Father</i>	11 speeches · 155 words
<i>Player 1</i>	3 speeches · 36 words
<i>Player 3</i>	3 speeches · 15 words
<i>Player 2</i>	4 speeches · 40 words
<i>Player 1 (as Door-keeper)</i>	1 speech · 5 words
Total	36 speeches · 443 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Father's long monologues are the philosophical engine of the act. They must be played as urgent, not as essays. A man arguing for his life is not a man lecturing.
- The Son's refusal is itself a performance. He should be aware of how dramatic his refusal is. That awareness is the comedy underneath the metaphysics.
- The Manager's pivot from cynic to interested party is the act's quiet pivot. Play it with both relief and unease.
- The final actor chorus is comic relief after a metaphysical climb. Don't undercut it; let the audience laugh again before the act ends.
- The Step-Daughter's narration of the shop scene must already contain the cold accounting we will hear from Madame Pace in Act Two. She is rehearsing the transaction for herself even as she describes it.
- By the curtain, the work-lights are gone and the rehearsal-room atmosphere is gone. We are inside the family's drama now, even though officially we are still backstage.

THE MANAGER. Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[coming forward]*. When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER *[shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the MANAGER]*. You be quiet!

THE MANAGER *[reflecting]*. It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

THE FATHER. No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

THE MANAGER *[he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind]*. God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level]*. Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the ACTORS.]* Be punctual, please! *[MANAGER and the Six CHARACTERS cross the stage and go off. The other ACTORS remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

PLAYER 1. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 3. They are not ordinary strangers.

PLAYER 2. No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) *[the cap forgotten in his hand; Player 1's posture leaking through the doorman's apology]*. I only let them in.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

PLAYER 1. They looked expected.

PLAYER 3. Am I taking this down?

PLAYER 2. Take everything down. It may be evidence.

Thus talking, the *ACTORS* leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.



— *End of Act I* —

The interval — about twenty minutes, and the production's only one. The chair-circle is struck and the two-level set of Act Two built behind the curtain. From the top of Act Two the play runs unbroken to the end: Act Three follows Act Two behind the dropped curtain, with no second interval, so the whole second half builds in one sweep to the fountain.

ACT THE SECOND

II

. . .

The Theatre — the play inside the play; the company stages the unstageable

The Setup

The act opens with a transformation of the set. The bare chair-circle of Act One is gone; what is revealed is built on two levels. The upper platform is the rehearsal stage — where the family's drama will be staged. The lower floor is everything outside the performance: where the actors watch, where the Six wait between scenes, where the technical apparatus of the house lives. The Step-Daughter erupts from the lower floor onto the upper platform with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair dragged behind her. She has just lost an argument we did not witness. The Son and Mother emerge after her on the lower floor, circling each other in silence and accusation. The Father follows last.

The stage darkens around her. The shower-light falls on her only — a tight overhead column, narrow enough for one performer and not two. She kneels with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair leaning beside her, and she speaks, alone, to her two silent siblings. The pianist plays Satie's *Gymnopédie No. 1* underneath. The monologue is live, in person, in the column of light: tender to the Child-bundle as if it were a real four-year-old; turning, mid-speech, to seize the coat hanging on the chair and take the revolver from its pocket. The audience does not need a screen for any of it. The speech is to the Child-bundle and the chair; the actor's care for both does the work.

Then the apparatus of the theatre reasserts itself — all of it now on the upper platform. The Property Man carries the table up. The Machinist places the pegs. The folding screen is wheeled into position. The white parlour is fitted up on the upper level, built around the family's pain like furniture, because that is what theatres do with grief. The Prompter takes shorthand from his box on the lower floor. The Manager paces between levels as he assigns names to the Characters. The Father falters at the sound of his own name.

Playing the act. Act Two is the theatre trying to build a real wound out of props and doubles: keep the procedural stretches — the set, the casting, the shorthand — brisk and businesslike, so the shower-light, the apparition, and the Mother's cry land hard against them. The act asks whether a stage can hold a real thing; the answer arrives with Madame Pace and is sealed by *It's taking place now*.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	13 speeches · 282 words
<i>The Father</i>	20 speeches · 393 words
<i>The Manager</i>	35 speeches · 735 words
<i>The Son</i>	2 speeches · 132 words
<i>The Mother</i>	2 speeches · 34 words

<i>Player 3</i>	4 speeches · 32 words
<i>Player 1</i>	6 speeches · 53 words
<i>Player 2</i>	11 speeches · 97 words
<i>The Manager and The Father</i>	1 speech · 5 words
Total	94 speeches · 1,763 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Step-Daughter's opening monologue is the production's most exposed solo moment. Alone in the shower-light, with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair at her side, she speaks to her two silent siblings as real children. The audience is asked to hold two things at once — that the Child-bundle is a four-year-old and that the chair is a fourteen-year-old — and they will, if the actor does.
- The tonal turn inside the monologue is the cue point. Tender to the Child for the first half. Then, on *What have you got there?*, she reaches for the coat hanging on the chair, takes the revolver from its pocket, and the speech turns. The light does not change; the voice does, and the body. The audience reads the shift before they can name it.
- The Mother's circling of the Son is a silent duel. Stage it physically — proximity, evasion, the refusal to meet the eyes. No words yet.
- The Property Man should bring in the furniture as if for any other rehearsal, not as if for a family's tragedy. The casualness of the work is the cruelty of this part.
- The Father's stumble at his own name is the small moment that signals the rest of the act. Mark it. Do not over-play it.
- Use the working lights again here for the technical setup that follows the monologue. Atmospheric lighting comes back only when Madame Pace is summoned.

SCORING THE MANAGER ACROSS THE PRODUCTION

The reading the actor must commit to: a tired director, not a symbol. *He spends the day trying to solve a rehearsal problem — and the house recognises itself in him precisely because he reacts as they would: practically, selfishly, curiously, and too late. Let the resemblance emerge from that behaviour; never let him play I am the audience. The closing exit lands because a real, tired man has had enough and goes — and the house realises, a beat late, that they were about to do the same.*

- **The seat-posture.** He sits at his table the way the audience sits in their seats — forward, slightly bored, half-engaged. Block him so the audience can read this. He is not on stage in the way the

Characters are on stage. He is between the audience and the play.

- **The audience's attention, embodied.** When the play becomes uncomfortable, he looks down — the way the audience does when something on stage is more than they want to look at. He leans in on *God help me, it tempts me* — the moment the audience leans in. He retreats again when the Father becomes too philosophical, when the Step-Daughter becomes too direct, when the Mother begins to cry — the audience looking for somewhere else to put their attention. All of it carried by body and breath, not by a prop.
- **His verbal tics are the audience's verbal tics.** *I don't understand this at all. Let's hear them out. What does that mean? Where does all this take us? Yes, yes, I know this. Damned good. Effect certain.* These are not director's notes. They are the things the audience is thinking. Score them so the audience hears their own thoughts coming out of him.
- **The pivot moment — when he stops being audience and becomes accessory.** Up to the middle of Act Three he is the man who watches and judges. Then he picks up the Boy-chair himself and places it behind the fountain. From that gesture forward, he is no longer the audience — he is the audience's *complicity* made physical. The man who has decided, against his own better judgement, that what happened to the Step-Daughter can be staged as *scene one*. The audience should feel themselves implicated when he sets that chair down. Stage the move with weight.
- **The closing exit is the audience's own.** *Pretence? Reality?* — a look at the empty Boy-chair — *To hell with it all.* Then he walks out. The audience's first impulse is to leave with him; he has done them the favour of going first, and condemned them with it in the same breath. Play it straight. No commentary, no irony. A tired man turning his back on a dead child and reaching for his coat. The damage lands in the silence after.
- **What he never quite admits — and the audience does not either.** He almost understands what he is watching. He never quite says so. He is the man who walks out of the theatre with a great play in his hands and pretends it was just a day. Give him compassion. He is — in his way — the bravest person in the room. The one who tried to make sense of it on a deadline. So is the audience. They will recognise him on the way out, in the lobby mirror, with their own program in their hand.
- **His Lausanne specificity beneath the symbol.** He has run the Village Players for years. He has been overcharged by Madame Pace's shop. He has had drinks at the bar after every premiere. He is faintly contemptuous of Pirandello and faintly proud of his Players. He almost says the playwright's name in Act Three Part II — comes within one breath of it — and stops himself. The audience should feel the gap. The local detail keeps him a man. The symbol keeps him bigger than that.

The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER comes out of the **MANAGER**'s office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the Child-bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the Boy-chair to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

The stage darkens around her. The shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, slow and child-haunted, beneath what follows. She kneels with the Child-bundle held against her chest, the Boy-chair leaning a short pace away. She speaks the next monologue live, alone in the column of light.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the Child-bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to the Child.]* Don't be afraid, Rosetta. It's only a stage — a place where they make false things and call them true. A garden, a fountain — just suppose it, here, in the middle. All make-believe, my pet; and better so, for a real one would only frighten you. *[A pang.]* You who are real, baby dear — who really played by a real fountain, green and beautiful, with the little ducks. *[She sets the Child-bundle down carefully and reaches for the coat on the Boy-chair, taking it by the sleeve as if by the boy's arm.]* And you — what have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver, holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah. Where did you get this? Idiot. If I had been in your place — instead of killing myself, I'd have shot one of those two. Or both. Father and son.

The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

THE MANAGER *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The FATHER, MANAGER and STEP-DAUGHTER go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, THE SON followed by THE MOTHER, comes out.]*

THE SON *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. *[The MOTHER attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the Child-bundle into her lap and draws the Boy-chair close beside her. She casts a glance again at the SON, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

THE MOTHER. Isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the SON's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

The MOTHER rises. She takes one step toward the SON, the Child-bundle still in her arms.

THE MOTHER *[barely]*. My son —

The SON turns away before the word is finished. She stops where she is; the unfinished word stays in the air between them. After a moment she sits again, and holds the Child-bundle a little lower, as though it had grown heavier in her arms.

THE SON *[half to himself, meaning the MOTHER to hear — eyes on the floor]*. And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about *my* case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

PLAYER 3 *[very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand]*. *Mon Dieu*. I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

The MOTHER hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the ACTORS and STAGE MANAGER return, followed by the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER. At the same moment, THE MANAGER comes out of his office, accompanied by the FATHER and the STEP-DAUGHTER.

THE MANAGER *[trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning]*. Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

PLAYER 1 *[two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man]*. Yes, sir.

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

The MACHINIST runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while THE MANAGER talks with the STAGE MANAGER, the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER on matters of detail.

THE MANAGER *[to PROPERTY MAN]*. Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

PLAYER 2 *[the Property Man's voice, flat and certain]*. There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

PLAYER 2 *[to MANAGER]*. There's that little gilt one.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

PLAYER 2. That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

THE MANAGER *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER]*. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything]*. Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

PLAYER 2 *[a half-nod; she is already on her way]*. Right.

The PROPERTY MAN hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the MANAGER talks to the PROMPTER and then with the CHARACTERS and the ACTORS.

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

PLAYER 3 *[looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour]*. Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand?*

THE MANAGER *[pleasantly surprised]*. Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

PLAYER 3. Yes, a little.

THE MANAGER. Good! *[Turning to a STAGE HAND.]* Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. *[The STAGE HAND goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the PROMPTER.]*

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. *[Then addressing the ACTORS.]* Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here *[Pointing to the left.]* and listen attentively.

PLAYER 2. But, excuse me, we...

THE MANAGER *[guessing her thought]*. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

PLAYER 1. What do we do, then — sit and applaud?

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

THE FATHER *[as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage]*. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. *[Points to the ACTORS.]*

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" *[Pointing towards PROMPTER'S box.]* — when there is a "book"!

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

THE FATHER. As we are...

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

PLAYER 1 *[dry now, the joke costing him something]*. What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the SECOND LADY LEAD.]* You play the Mother. *[To the FATHER.]* We must find her a name.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... *[Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the SECOND LADY LEAD.]* I see this woman here *[Means the MOTHER.]* as Amalia. But do as you like. *[Gets more and more confused.]* I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To JUVENILE LEAD.]* You are the Son. *[To the LEADING LADY.]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? What? I — that woman there?

THE MANAGER *[angry]*. What is there to laugh at?

PLAYER 2 *[indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. You should feel honored to be played by...

PLAYER 2 *[at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Your soul, or whatever you like to call it, takes shape *here*: my actors give it body, voice, gesture. They have given voice to material far loftier than this little drama of yours — and if it holds the stage at all, the merit will be theirs.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

THE MANAGER *[cutting him short and out of patience]*. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up... On the stage, you as yourself cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

PLAYER 1 *[on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged]*. By me, if you've no objection.

THE FATHER *[with a small bow toward Player 1]*. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

PLAYER 1 *[the dignity cracking]*. Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

THE FATHER. It will be difficult to act me as I am. What you will see is how he imagines me — if he imagines me at all — never how I feel myself to be, in here. Whoever judges us ought to remember that.

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the ACTORS and CHARACTERS.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Is it all right as it is now?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the FATHER.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

THE FATHER. Yes.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The STAGE HANDS obey the order. To PROPERTY MAN.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates FATHER.]*

PLAYER 2. An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

PLAYER 2. At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. [*The LEADING LADY comes forward.*] No, no, you must wait. I meant her [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] You just watch —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*adding at once*]. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

PLAYER 2 [*offended*]. I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

THE MANAGER [*with his hands to his head*]. Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! [*Looks around as if lost.*] And this Madame Pace, where is she?

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done? I cannot rehearse a character who has not arrived.

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! [*Turning to the ACTRESSES.*] If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

PLAYER 1 [*half surprised, half laughing*]. Our hats?

What? Why? Our hats? What does he say?

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? [*The ACTORS laugh.*]

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

PLAYER 2. Why our hats?

Oh, what d'you think of that? Only the mantle? He must be mad.

PLAYER 3. Are we still rehearsing?

But why? Mantles as well?

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

The PLAYERS take off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and go to hang them on the racks.

After all, why not? There you are! This is really funny. We've got to put them on show.

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? [*Inviting the ACTORS to look towards the exit at back of stage.*] Look! Look!

The Apparition

The Father asks the actresses if they would mind hanging their hats and mantles on the pegs at the back of the upper platform. They climb up to do so, half-amused, not knowing why. The Father asks them to look toward the door upstage. The door opens. Madame Pace appears on the upper level — though she was not in the original six, and no one called her, and no one walks through a stage door on cue. The Step-Daughter, on the platform with her, recognises her at once.

This is the production's strangest scene, and the most architecturally bold. A Character not in the original cast list is summoned onto the upper level by the very arrangement of the stage — by the hats on the pegs, by the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), by the folding screen. She is played by a performer of her own — no Player steps into a costume in view of the house; the door opens and she is simply there, the way an apparition enters a body. She is fat, bleach-blonde, rouged — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in Lausanne long enough to half-forget her first language and never quite learn her second. She speaks English in a thick accent — Italian-Swiss and French both worn into it — and the actors laugh at the sound of her before they understand what it is saying. What it is saying is a procurement transaction. She is a bookkeeper of the trade — the silk the Mother has ruined, the column that must balance, the cash in the blue envelope, the chicken not slaughtered where the hen can see. The Step-Daughter begins to play the scene of the atelier with her, drawn back into a room she has been in before.

Then the Mother sees her, from the lower floor. The Mother, who has barely spoken in this play, looks up at the upper platform and erupts: *You old devil! You murderess!* Her voice crosses from below to above. And — surprising herself — it does not stop. She names the years, the kitchen, the silk, the tea she drank in Madame Pace's kitchen every Wednesday while her own daughter was just down the corridor. She half-knew, and let herself not know, because the alternative was the children going hungry. The temperature in the room collapses in seconds. The scene of the shop cannot be played in the presence of its witness. The play breaks its own scene, and the actors, watching from the wings, do not understand what they are watching. The Mother spends what she has, and is restored to silence by the end of the part — but she has used her voice, for the first time in the production, and the company has heard it.

Playing the apparition. Madame Pace is full comedy on her arrival and full chill by her exit — the company laughs at her accent before they understand what they are laughing at, and the laugh must curdle in the throat as the ledger comes clear (*he pay cash*). The Mother's outburst is the silent centre of the play finding voice for the only time: let it come out faster than her body can carry it, then cost her everything.

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	20 speeches · 382 words
<i>The Father</i>	12 speeches · 310 words
<i>The Manager</i>	15 speeches · 347 words
<i>Player 1</i>	4 speeches · 42 words
<i>Player 3</i>	2 speeches · 17 words
<i>Player 2</i>	1 speech · 8 words
<i>Madame Pace</i>	5 speeches · 566 words
<i>The Mother</i>	4 speeches · 190 words
Total	63 speeches · 1,862 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- Madame Pace's entrance must feel inexplicable to the audience. The folding screen, the hats, the shop window — let the audience read them as set-dressing, not as summoning.
- Madame Pace is the production's most demanding role, and her own performer carries it. The wig, the heels, the powder — every visual element must commit. The dialect must be performed with no protective irony.
- The Step-Daughter does not flirt with Madame Pace; she is being handled by her. Play the proximity as a woman who has been in this room before and knows the price of every silk. The audience may laugh at the dialect at first — that laughter must curdle inside Madame's "Not so old, my dear" aria.
- Madame Pace's arc is the whole point of her scene: she arrives comic and exits chilling. Mark the precise beat where the laughter in the room dies — somewhere between her opening *Good morning, good morning, sir* and her closing *Don't you forget the name*. If the audience is still laughing at her exit, she has not done her job. The smile never drops; only what she is saying changes.
- The pale blue envelope and the hundred francs are the props that make the scene material. Treat them with weight. They are not symbols; they are evidence.
- The Mother's eruption is triggered on a specific line — Madame Pace's *Not so old, my dear. He clean. He polite. He pay cash... The lady stay quiet too*. That is the beat that breaks her silence; mark it in the score. She has been silent for an entire act and a half. She finds her voice in one breath, and the room changes with her.
- The Mother's silence before and after that eruption is the architecture of the scene. The actor must commit to the silence as much as to the cry.

- The Mother has three silences across the play, and they are not the same silence. The first (Act One) is the silence of a woman who does not yet believe the room will hear her. The second (this part) is the silence of being made to watch her daughter's worst hour staged in front of her — and the silence that breaks in one breath when Madame Pace says *he pay cash*. The third (Act Three) is the silence of holding both children at once. Score each one separately. They have different bodies.

REHEARSAL NOTE · THE SHOP SCENE

This is the most sensitive sequence in the play, and the heart of it. The comedy around it — the hats, Madame Pace's accent, the Players' asides — belongs to the *company*, never to the scene itself. The scene is staged with care: no unnecessary physical contact, and every moment of intimacy or violence (the Father and the Step-Daughter, Madame Pace's hand, the revolver from the coat) is choreographed in advance and consented to, never improvised. Nothing here is left to the moment. See the Intimacy & Consent Protocol.

The door at the back of stage opens and MADAME PACE enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The STEP-DAUGHTER runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her]*. There she is! There she is!

THE FATHER *[radiant]*. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

THE MANAGER *[conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]*. What sort of a trick is this?

PLAYER 1 *[almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there]*. What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

PLAYER 3. Where did *she* come from? She wasn't here a moment ago. She wasn't anywhere.

PLAYER 2. It's some trick. Someone arranged this. *[the certainty leaves her]* ...Didn't they?

THE FATHER *[dominating the protests]*. Excuse me — all of you. Why so eager to destroy, in the name of your ordinary little truth, a thing the stage itself has just conjured into being? Which of your actresses was to play Madame Pace? Here she is — Madame Pace herself. Any actress you cast would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

But the scene between the *STEP-DAUGHTER* and *MADAME PACE* has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of *THE FATHER*. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by *THE FATHER*, turn round and see *MADAME PACE*, who has placed one hand under the *STEP-DAUGHTER*'s chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

PLAYER 1 [*cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house*]. What does she say? Madame — speak up.

PLAYER 3. Louder! Louder please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*leaving MADAME PACE, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors*]. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. [*Indicates FATHER.*] But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

The STEP-DAUGHTER, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*low, no theatrics*]. There's someone who will hear us if she [*Indicating MADAME PACE.*] speaks out loud.

THE MANAGER [*in consternation*]. What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? [*The ACTORS burst out laughing.*]

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. [*Moves away.*]

THE MANAGER [*stopping him*]. No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*interrupting him*]. No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

THE MANAGER [*shouting*]. But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... [*Indicates MADAME PACE.*] Do you understand?...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

MADAME PACE *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good morning, good morning, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

Note. MADAME PACE speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed].* What? What? She talks like that? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing again.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing].* Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

MADAME PACE. It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

THE MANAGER. Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

MADAME PACE. Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

THE MOTHER *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it].* You old devil! You murderess! *[Trembling, but the voice does not stop.]* Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame,

every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. *[Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.]* May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her MOTHER — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her].* Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

THE MOTHER *[she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long].* And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

THE FATHER *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

THE MOTHER *[the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had].* Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to MANAGER].* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER].* They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the MOTHER and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Meanwhile, the **STEP-DAUGHTER**, coming forward again, turns to **MADAME PACE**.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

MADAME PACE *[offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned].* Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. *[Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.]* The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the COMPANY imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To MADAME PACE.]* You can go!

MADAME PACE *[adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once].* Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. *[Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.]* And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. *[Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.]* There is always the next silk, my dear.

There is always the debt. There is always Pace. *[The scissors swing once more at her waist.]* Don't you forget the name.
[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to the FATHER]*. Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good afternoon, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the FATHER, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

The FATHER does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The ACTORS watch intently.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the PROMPTER in his box]*. Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

THE FATHER *[coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling]*. Good afternoon, Miss.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust]*. Good afternoon!

THE FATHER *[looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure]*. Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the rehearsed bow — no softness in it]*. No sir.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

The MOTHER, who watches the progress of the scene with THE SON beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.

THE MOTHER *[without lifting her head from her hands]*. Oh, my God. My God.

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry]*. Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 1 *[interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig]*. I say... those are *our* hats, you know.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Begin again, please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[continuing]*. No thank you, sir.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, not pleading]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her black dress, once.]*

THE FATHER *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.]*. ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea]*. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[interrupting and turning to the PROMPTER]*. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the FATHER only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the ACTORS.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! *[To the ACTORS.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

PLAYER 1. Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

The Substitution

The Father and the Step-Daughter play out the first beats of the shop scene themselves, on the upper platform. The lines they say are the lines they actually said, some years ago, in a back room of a real dressmaker's atelier in Lausanne. The Manager listens from below. The actors watch from below. The Mother trembles on the lower floor. Then the Manager hands the scene to his Leading Lady and Leading Man — they climb up to the platform, taking the place of the Characters, and try the same lines. The Step-Daughter, also up there, laughs at them.

The Players push through it: the hat-offer, the refusal, the mourning reveal, the *I'm frightfully sorry*. They do not break on a laugh. They break on a correction. The Step-Daughter, almost to herself: *He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.* The Father, quietly: *Yes. He said "Oh."* The Leading Lady will not be corrected this precisely by the originals of her part, and she walks. The Leading Man walks after her. The Mother, from the lower floor, breaks in: *It's taking place now. It happens all the time.* She cries out as she did in life, from below up into the rehearsal stage. The Machinist, by accident, drops the curtain on what was supposed to be only a rehearsal effect.

This is the act's first real climax. Pirandello forces the audience to watch the same scene twice and feel both versions as inadequate — the live one too raw, the rehearsed one too polished. The audience leaves the act unsettled and a little ashamed of having been entertained.

Playing the substitution. The doubled scene must never tip into parody — the Leading Man and Leading Lady play it straight and competent; the horror is that it is *good*, and still false. Watch the Characters, not the actors: the Father turning away, the Step-Daughter's laugh hardening into a stare. The hinge is tiny — *He said "Oh."* — and the Mother's *It's taking place now* is the key to the whole production: the wound is not remembered, it is lived again, every night. The accidental curtain falls in earnest — the Machinist means it.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>Player 2</i>	11 speeches · 149 words
<i>Player 1</i>	11 speeches · 171 words
<i>The Manager</i>	39 speeches · 625 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	23 speeches · 578 words
<i>The Father</i>	11 speeches · 150 words
<i>The Mother</i>	4 speeches · 107 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- Two performances of the same shop scene, back to back, must feel like two genres. The Characters' version is shame in real time; the Actors' version is rehearsal-room polish — competent, well-paced, well-meaning, and exactly wrong. The Leading Lady's voice catches where she has been taught it should catch. That is the cruelty.
- The Step-Daughter's laughter at the Leading Lady must not be mocking. It must be heartbroken. She is watching her worst hour be made decorative.
- The Leading Lady and Leading Man — Players 2 and 1 — must not be in on the joke. They believe they are doing fine work. They walk out not from humiliation but from professional offence: *I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath*. The audience should be embarrassed for them and for itself.
- The Mother's *It's taking place now* is the moral centre of the play. Surround it with silence. Let the actors freeze around her. Then the curtain falls before they can recover.
- The accidental curtain-drop must look genuinely accidental. The Machinist (Player 1) should look surprised. The audience should be unsure for a half-second whether the play is over.
- The act ends not on a line but on the collapse of the curtain. Calibrate the descent — neither slow nor fast, but inevitable.

SCORING PLAYER 2 ACROSS THE PRODUCTION

The reading the actor must commit to: about thirty-five, and the real working professional Player 1 only impersonates. She is younger than him and better at the job — she has already played leads at every Lausanne house, and she knows the audience by name. She also, because the company is small and the budget smaller, does the props. She is not the eldest in the room; she is the one who actually books the work. Her authority is in her shoulders, not her years.

- **The flip is in the bearing.** No prop signals it. For the Leading Lady, the chest lifts, the chin raises, the voice carries. For the Property Man, the shoulders come down, the weight goes forward, the voice goes flat and functional. The actor inhabits both postures so cleanly that the audience reads the flip every time it happens.
- **Two registers, one woman.** The Leading Lady is weary, slightly offended, deeply professional — the diva is real, the diva is earned, the diva is tired. The Property Man is the same woman with her sleeves rolled up: efficient, vaguely irritated, the patience exhausted. She *chose* to do the props because the company couldn't afford a real one. Both are work. Both are paid in francs.

- **The wound.** When she climbs onto the upper platform to play the Step-Daughter, and is laughed at by a woman half her age who has actually been through the room she is being asked to fake — that laugh is what breaks her. The diva's posture collapses. The voice changes. *I have been made a fool of by considerably better* is not a punchline. It is the truth, and she means it.
- **Where Player 1 is defensive, she is direct.** Where his vanity is a performance, hers is earned. The Step-Daughter's laugh hurts her more than the same laugh hurts him, because she has staked more of her life on this profession. Score the contrast.
- **Act Three.** By the third act she would like to be at home with the cat. She is one of the Players who, by then, knows the play has run away from them and is being polite about it. Her last lines are short — *Is this still the play, or has it become something else?* — and they land because she has earned them across the production.

PLAYER 2 [*the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this*]. Of course. It's easy enough. [*To LEADING MAN.*] Shall you and I try it now?

PLAYER 1. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [*Exit to make his entrance.*]

THE MANAGER [*to LEADING LADY*]. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. [*Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.*]

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 [*an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed*]. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER [*to STEP-DAUGHTER*]. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. [*Clapping his hands.*] Come on! come on! Entrance, please! [*The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the STEP-DAUGHTER and the FATHER, not being able to recognize themselves in the LEADING LADY and the LEADING MAN, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.*]

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER [*at once unable to contain himself*]. No! no!

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

THE MANAGER [*furious*]. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady [*Indicating LEADING LADY.*] stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 [*the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks*]. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. [*Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.*] Well?

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2. Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 [*imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear*]. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. [*Acts it himself.*] And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2. No, sir.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" [*The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*unable to contain herself*]. Oh my God! [*Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.*]

THE MANAGER [*turning round*]. What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER [*to LEADING MAN*]. Go on!

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The LEADING MAN says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the STEP-DAUGHTER, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

THE MANAGER [*low, firm, to the players*]. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 [*recovering, back into the rehearsed register*]. No sir... I'll do it myself. [*Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.*]

PLAYER 1 *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *[the smile he has used a thousand times]*. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

PLAYER 1 *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

PLAYER 2 *[the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the PROMPTER]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *[breaking character, to MANAGER]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

PLAYER 2 *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

PLAYER 1 *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

THE FATHER. Just so — actors. They act our parts exceedingly well. But what comes out is theirs now, and no longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! [*Turning to the ACTORS.*] We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! [*Turning to FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.*] Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you [*Addressing the FATHER.*] come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*interrupting*]. What?

THE MANAGER. Why she is in mourning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. What do you want to do then?

THE MANAGER. You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off.*

THE MANAGER [*running his hands through his hair*]. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*no longer playing*]. The truth. The truth.

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

THE MANAGER. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part.*

THE MANAGER [*annoyed, shaking his shoulders*]. Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his [*Indicating the Father.*] and hers [*Indicating the Mother.*]. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. [*softening, sitting on the edge of the table*] You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*head lowered, not yielding*]. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

THE MANAGER [*not understanding*]. What? The others? What do you mean?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? [*She is moved.*] [*The MOTHER at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*as soon as the MOTHER becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely*]. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

THE MOTHER [*changing her low plaint into a sharp cry*]. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

THE MOTHER [*to the Child-bundle, not to the room*]. I can't bear it. I can't.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

THE MOTHER *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech].* It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]*

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them].* No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

THE MANAGER *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk].* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly].* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

THE MANAGER *[convinced and pleased].* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

At the reiterated cry of **THE MANAGER**, **THE MACHINIST** lets the curtain down, leaving **THE MANAGER** and **THE FATHER** in front of it before the footlights.

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the FATHER, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

✦

— End of Act II —

No interval here. Behind the curtain that has just fallen by accident, the two-level set is struck and the fountain set in a fast change; Act Three

follows at once, with no break in the audience's attention.

ACT THE THIRD

III

. . .

The Question — pretence against reality, and no clean way out of either

The Trap

The curtain rises on an otherwise empty stage with a single short fountain basin in the middle. The two-level set of Act Two is gone — struck behind the dropped curtain in a fast scene change, not an interval; Act Three follows Act Two without a break. There is no garden, no backdrop, no trees, no painted cardboard. Only the basin: stone or concrete, with walls high enough that nobody can see inside it. The Boy-chair — the Boy — has been moved to the edge of the stage. The bundle is in the Step-Daughter's arms.

The Manager is plotting how to stage a tragedy on an empty stage with one prop. The Step-Daughter complains that this stripped set cannot hold the whole drama, because the Son spends most of the action shut in his room; how can an empty stage contain a man who refuses to come into it? The Father, suddenly philosophical, objects to the word *illusion*. He says the Characters have no other reality outside this one — that the Manager's reality, by contrast, may seem an illusion to him tomorrow. *Can you tell me who you are?*

This is the play's most philosophical stretch. The Father becomes, almost openly, the dramatist that Pirandello cannot help being. The Manager refuses the bait but is visibly unsettled. The Step-Daughter is impatient with the metaphysics — she wants the drama played, not theorised. Yet the Father's argument holds, because of how directly it is aimed: at the Manager, at the actors, at us. The audience is being asked, without warning, whether it exists in the same way the Characters do.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	22 speeches · 250 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	9 speeches · 177 words
<i>The Mother</i>	2 speeches · 28 words
<i>Player 1</i>	2 speeches · 18 words
<i>Player 2</i>	3 speeches · 41 words
<i>The Father</i>	16 speeches · 471 words
Total	54 speeches · 985 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

— The stripped stage of Act Three is the most demanding visual decision. Resist the urge to dress it up. One fountain basin, four live Characters, the Boy-chair at the side, an empty floor. Light does

the rest.

- The Father's *Can you tell me who you are?* must be aimed not at the Manager but at the audience. The actor should let the question land in the house, not on the stage.
- The Manager's discomfort during the philosophical stretch is the audience's discomfort — play him as a man who would like to leave but cannot.
- The Step-Daughter's impatience keeps the philosophy from becoming a lecture. Use her interruptions.
- The bundle remains in her arms throughout this part. The chair remains at the edge. The Boy and Child are present as objects through every philosophical sentence; the philosophy is happening over their silent bodies.
- The Mother is holding both children at once in this act — the Child-bundle in her arms, the Boy-chair leaning against her knee. Her hands are her score: watch what they do when the Father reaches for a beautiful word. The grip should tighten on the Child-bundle at *illusion*, at *reality*, and at the Step-Daughter's *he always knew exactly where to find me*. Three small, involuntary tightenings. Mark them.
- The Manager's misnumbering of his own act (*Ah yes: the second act!*) is a quiet joke. Let it land lightly. The audience will catch it.

SCORING THE FATHER — FOUR STAGES

Do not let his philosophy stay as intellectual speeches. It should become a physical event onstage. Make the audience feel it, not just understand it. The wrong way is calm, beautiful, polite — a professor explaining ideas. The Father is not lecturing. He is fighting for his existence.

- **1. Control.** Hands folded. Voice smooth. Small steps. Eyes on the Manager. He wants to win through reason. The feeling is: *please understand me*.
- **2. Injury.** The word *illusion* lands physically. He turns too quickly. Breath catches. Hands tighten. The face changes before he speaks. This is the audience's first proof that the debate is not abstract. The feeling becomes: *do not call my existence fake*.
- **3. Attack.** *Can you tell me who you are?* He starts facing the Manager — and slowly turns out toward the house. He lets the question land in the audience. He waits. The Father is no longer only defending himself; he is attacking everyone else's certainty. The feeling is: *you think I am unreal? Prove that you are real*.
- **4. Horror.** By the final speech he is not winning the argument. He is realising what he has just proved: if his reality is fixed forever, he is fixed forever as the guilty Father, the man caught in shame, the man the Step-Daughter will never forgive, the man who can never escape the scene.

The ending stillness is not the opening stillness. The opening stillness is control. The ending stillness is horror. The feeling becomes: *yes — I am real, and that is my punishment.*

HOW TO MAKE THE PHILOSOPHY THEATRICAL

- **The body changes through the speech.** Stage 1: upright, balanced, contained. Stages 2–3: stepping closer to the Manager, hands opening and closing, breathing visible, no longer elegant. Stage 4: still again — but the stillness is different. The first stillness is composure. The last is paralysis.
 - **Silence before *Can you tell me who you are?*** The question must feel dangerous. Pause before it. Let the room feel it coming. Then deliver it half to the Manager, half to the house.
 - **Silence after the Step-Daughter cuts him.** When she says *he always knew exactly where to find me*, he should not answer immediately. For one beat, philosophy cannot protect him. She has pulled him back to the fact. His face changes. Then he continues — but the argument is no longer clean. It is desperate.
 - **Two opponents, two registers.** With the Manager he can dominate. With the Step-Daughter he cannot. That contrast must be visible. Powerful against the Manager. Wounded against her. Never the same body twice.
 - **The audience as the third opponent.** Halfway through the philosophy he should stop speaking only to the Manager. The audience is also watching him as fiction. Make them feel implicated. Make them ask themselves the same question.
 - **The shape of his performance in one sentence.** A wound becoming an argument, an argument becoming an attack, an attack becoming a confession, a confession becoming a prison. He should not end like a man who has won. He should end like a man who has just proved the walls of his own cell.
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SCORING THE STEP-DAUGHTER THROUGH THE PHILOSOPHY

She must not disappear while the Father speaks. She is the moral centre of the play and she cannot let him become the hero of this scene. She cuts him three times. Each cut returns the abstraction to the actual fact. None of them is screamed. None of them is messy. The colder she is, the more she wins.

- **First cut** — after his "the very earth under your feet is sinking" speech. *His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.* The room must drop a degree. He must have no answer.
- **Second cut** — after he says *more real than I am? But of course. Without doubt.* She names the fact behind his "reality": *He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.* Not to

him — to the room. The Manager's "Ah, really?" should now sound different, because what he is answering is no longer just metaphysics.

- **Third cut** — immediately before his final immutable-reality cry. *His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.* This is the line that pushes him into the wall. The horror that follows is not his philosophy proving itself — it is her having said the thing his philosophy was designed to hide.
- **Register.** Level. Flat. Never screamed. The temperature beneath her voice is the colder the air gets. She is in pain, but she does not let the pain leak into the cut. She is in control of the room every time she opens her mouth.
- **Between cuts.** She is still on stage, the Child-bundle in her arms. The audience reads her watching him. Choose her exact gaze for the philosophy — at him, past him, at the floor. The actor must decide and commit; the audience will read the choice.

When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **MOTHER** is sitting on the right, the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair leaned against her knee. The **SON** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **FATHER** and the **STEP-DAUGHTER** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **ACTORS**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **MANAGER** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.

THE MANAGER [shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house [Indicates **FATHER**.] in spite of him... [Indicates the **SON**.]

THE MANAGER [out of patience]. Leave it to me, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

THE MOTHER [from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice]. For all the good that's come of it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [turning towards her quickly]. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

THE MANAGER [impatiently]. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

THE MOTHER [the Child-bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it]. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [interrupting indignantly and continuing for the **MOTHER**]... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. [To **MANAGER**.] Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

THE MANAGER. Why not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he *[Indicates the SON again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

PLAYER 1. They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

PLAYER 2. It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]*. The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

PLAYER 1. With our acting.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer]*. I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

PLAYER 2 *[interrupting indignantly]*. A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five CHARACTERS.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

THE MANAGER *[astonished, looking at his ACTORS, who are also amazed]*. And what does that mean?

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile]*. As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the MANAGER and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by

the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the MANAGER in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

THE MANAGER *[perplexed, half smiling]*. What? Who am I? I am myself.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the LEADING MAN.]* to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. *[Quiet.]* You see — I've caught you in a *trap*. *[The ACTORS laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the LEADING LADY as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *[Beat.]* *Who are you?*

THE MANAGER *[astonished and irritated, turning to his ACTORS]*. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

THE FATHER *[with dignity, but not offended]*. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

THE FATHER. Only this: the man you are today once believed himself someone else entirely — someone who now means nothing to you, who barely seems to have existed. Don't you feel the ground go soft under you, knowing this *you* of today will look like an illusion to you tomorrow?

PLAYER 2 *[whispering]*. Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy]*. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

A silence. The **FATHER** does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.

THE MANAGER *[rattled now, and covering it]*. Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to this: we *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* have nothing but the illusion you call our reality. And you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

THE MANAGER *[mocking him because the idea has unsettled him]*. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

THE FATHER *[the greatest seriousness — no smile]*. But of course. Without doubt.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the same temperature; addressing the room, not him]*. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[before the Father can answer — flat, precise]*. His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

THE FATHER *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has shown him]*. No, sir. Not ours. That is the difference. Our reality cannot change — it is fixed, forever; it cannot be other than what it is. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* And that is what should make you shudder as you come near us: yours shifts with the day, and ours is nailed shut. We are the thing we did. And we will do it again tonight. And tomorrow. And every night you choose to put us on.

PART II OF ACT THREE

The Refusal

The Manager tries to combine the garden scene and the indoor scene into one staged action — though there is no garden and no indoor scene, only the fountain basin and the empty stage. The Boy-chair is to be moved behind the fountain, where it will be partly hidden by the basin. The Child-bundle is to be brought down to the basin by the Step-Daughter. The Son is to enter from somewhere off and approach the fountain in time to see the drowning.

The Son refuses. He will not act this. He has never agreed to act it. He cannot leave, but he can refuse to participate, and he intends to. The Step-Daughter laughs at his refusal — he cannot leave, she tells him, because he is *indissolubly bound to the chain*. The Son delivers his speech on the mirror that throws his own likeness back at him as a horrible grimace. He is, in his own family, an image he cannot live with. The Father tries to force him to play the scene. The Mother begs. The Son does not move.

This is the Son's hour. He refuses the play and yet remains in it — the perfect Pirandellian condition. He is the one who has been right all along, and being right does not save him from anything.

Playing the philosophy. The Father's defence of his own talking must escalate in desperation, never merely repeat; the Manager's mounting frustration is the audience's. If the stretch sags in the room, cut into it — the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	16 speeches · 610 words
<i>The Father</i>	15 speeches · 401 words
<i>Player 1</i>	1 speech · 8 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	9 speeches · 411 words
<i>Player 3</i>	1 speech · 20 words
<i>The Son</i>	7 speeches · 69 words
Total	49 speeches · 1,519 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

— The Son must be physically isolated. Other actors around him; him alone in his frame. Stage him to be unmoveable, not still.

- The Step-Daughter taunts him because she knows he cannot leave. The taunt is therefore loving, not cruel. Find that note.
- The Mother trembles because she knows it too. Her trembling is involuntary, not performed.
- The mirror speech is the Son's only real cry. He must arrive at it. Do not let him perform it from the first beat — he must be surprised, mid-speech, by what he is saying.
- The Boy-chair is moved behind the fountain basin during this part. Stage the move with weight. The audience should notice a chair being placed behind a basin in an empty stage.
- The Manager is exhausted in this part. Play him as a director who has lost control of his rehearsal and has not yet admitted it.
- No laughter in the room. The comedy has burned off completely. What remains is grief that has not yet found a body.

SCORING THE SON IN THIS PART

This is his hour. The reading the actor must commit to: he is the only Character who agrees with the author who abandoned them. His refusal is not coldness; it is an aesthetic and ethical position. He will not let his life be made into theatre. That is what makes him the play's most modern figure — the adult child who has been told he must show up for a parent's narrative and has decided no.

- **Hands in his pockets the entire part.** They come out only when the Father grabs him. They go back in the moment they can. Score this; it is his refusal made physical.
- **He never looks at the Boy-chair or the Child-bundle.** They belong to a family he refuses to be the brother of. The Mother is sometimes glanced at, never held; the Father is addressed only when forced; the Manager is who he speaks to. Eyes mostly on the floor, the wall, the wings.
- **His one moment of looking up** — *Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that* — is the only beat in the whole part where his gaze meets another character's directly. Stage that meeting. It is the only place in the production where the Son is on the side of someone else's instinct. He is agreeing with the author. He wants this not to happen as much as the author did.
- **The mirror speech surprises him.** He arrives at it mid-thought. He has been refusing to feel, and the sentence comes out before he can stop it. Do not pre-load the emotion. Find it on the word *horrible*, not before.
- **After the mirror speech, he is more closed than before** — the wound he just exposed must be re-buried for him to get through the rest of the part. The "I do nothing" lines that follow are flatter, smaller, more final.
- **The shape of his refusal across the part.** Stage 1 — dismissal. Stage 2 — physical immobility. Stage 3 — the failed escape and the moment of being trapped. Stage 4 — the dignity that arrives

once he gives up trying to leave. He becomes more himself the more he is held in place.

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... [*Stops and looks him over from head to foot.*] Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. [*Turning to the Actors.*] And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

THE FATHER. I don't know your detested author, sir. I only know this: a man never thinks so hard as when he suffers — he must learn who did it to him, and whether he deserved it. Let me suffer in silence, like an animal, and you call it human. Let me ask *why*, and suddenly it is forbidden.

PLAYER 1 [*low, to Player 3*]. I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

THE MANAGER [*sharp now, no longer amused*]. Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

THE MANAGER. Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

THE FATHER. Because I am in pain, sir — and a man in pain reasons; he cannot help it. Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

THE MANAGER [*slaps the table*]. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

THE FATHER. Because authors hide the labour, sir. When a character is truly alive, the author only follows him — and the character takes on a life so far his own that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*quiet*]. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn — I, she [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] and she. [*Indicating the MOTHER.*]

PLAYER 3 *[to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room]*. Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. *[No one does.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I tempted him too — many times. He would sit at his writing-table at twilight, too tired to turn on the lamp, and the shadows would fill with us, come to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Let us live, I would whisper — the mother with her son, I with the little ones, and then I alone in the dark, offering him scene after scene. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? *[Goes close to the MANAGER to tell him, as if in confidence.]* In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

THE SON *[looking up, for once — directly at the Manager]*. Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

THE SON. No, nothing!

THE MANAGER. You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

THE FATHER *[genuinely surprised, almost wounded]*. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

THE FATHER. Take away my torment, sir — the torment that never gives me peace — and you suppress me. That's all. A man does not merely live; he gives his own life a meaning. I will not be reduced to a mere fact, as she *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. *[Indicating FATHER.]* You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[He stands. He picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity made physical. He places the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must see the move land.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the SON.]* You must send him away first.

THE SON *[jumping up]*. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The MOTHER gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

THE SON *[to MANAGER who stops him]*. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly — she knows him]*. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

THE SON *[the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives]*. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the MANAGER.]* Let me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager]*. Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, supporting that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose only son he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see, she was getting up to keep him back. You can imagine how little she wants to show your actors what she really feels — but so eager is she to get near him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

THE SON *[trapped now — and knowing it]*. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER excitedly]*. You can force him, sir.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

The Fountain

The Step-Daughter takes the Child-bundle to the fountain. She bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it — but the basin's walls are high enough that nobody, neither the audience nor the live actors, can see inside it. The drowning happens in plain sight, in an unseeable space. The Son finally tells what he saw on that afternoon: he ran across the garden, he jumped to drag the Child out of the water, and he was frozen by the sight of the Boy standing stock still by the side of the fountain, his face stricken, watching his little sister in the water.

As the Son speaks, the stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, until only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare hanging bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair sits behind the basin where the Manager has placed it earlier in the act. For ten seconds, in that low water-light, the audience sees the silhouette of the chair against the cold water — the Boy watching his little sister in the water. Then full blackout. Then, out of the dark, the gunshot — from behind the basin, where the Boy-chair is. The Mother cries out. The actors lift what they think is the Boy's body, which is the Boy-chair now being treated as a body. Some say he is dead. Others say it is only pretence. The Father, with a terrible cry: *Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!* The Manager has had enough: he looks at the empty Boy-chair, says *Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all*, and walks out the way a man leaves a theatre. Curtain.

The climax is delivered as memory, not as scene. The drowning is hidden by the basin itself — its walls do the work the Step-Daughter's body used to do. The light fades until only the silhouette of a chair behind a basin remains: the act of watching, not the act of dying. Then the dark. Then the shot. This is Pirandello's strictest cruelty: the most terrible thing in the play is the thing the audience does not actually see happen.

Playing the climax. Carry it by stillness, not volume: the Son's account is flat — he tells it because he can no longer hold it in, not to perform it; the Mother's discovery is physical, the veil never lifting; and the silence after the shot is the loudest thing in the play. Let nobody push.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	1 speech · 15 words
<i>The Manager</i>	15 speeches · 131 words
<i>The Son</i>	17 speeches · 281 words
<i>The Mother</i>	6 speeches · 74 words
<i>Player 3</i>	1 speech · 7 words

<i>The Father</i>	6 speeches · 67 words
<i>Player 1 & Player 3</i>	1 speech · 3 words
<i>Player 2</i>	1 speech · 9 words
Total	48 speeches · 587 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Step-Daughter at the fountain is the play's last live image of love. She is holding a bundle and bending over a basin whose interior nobody can see. Stage the action with the tenderness of the Act Two opening — and trust the basin to do the hiding for you.
- The Son's narration must be the slowest passage in the third act. He is the man who could not move; let his words refuse to move too.
- The ten-second held silhouette must feel unhurried. As the lights drop, the silhouette of the Boy-chair against the cold basin water should hold long enough for the audience to register what they are looking at — the Boy watching his little sister in the water — and to feel the cost of having had to read it.
- The gunshot must be a single, sharp report. Choose between startling the audience and not blowing out the speakers.
- The actors lifting the Boy-chair must treat it as a body. Heavy. Carried with care. The audience reads what the actors give them.
- *Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!* must not be played as resolution. Play it as a contradiction the play cannot solve. The line is a wound, not an answer.
- The Manager's last line is not a punchline. He is tired and contemptuous and right and wrong. Play him as the man who has had enough and turns his back. Then the curtain comes down on his exhaustion, not on the family's tragedy.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... [*Lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.*]

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

The **SECOND LADY LEAD** and the **JUVENILE LEAD** at this point separate themselves from the group of **ACTORS**. One watches the **MOTHER** attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the **SON** whom he will have to act.

THE SON *[to MANAGER]*. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]* Ask her how it was!

THE MOTHER. Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

THE SON. Into *my* room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

THE SON *[observing the JUVENILE LEAD studying him]*. What do you want?

PLAYER 3. Nothing! I was just looking at you.

THE SON *[turning towards the SECOND LADY LEAD]*. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

THE SON *[the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]*. Yes — but haven't you yet seen that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? One that doesn't simply hold your face, but throws it back at you — twisted into a grimace.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

THE MANAGER *[to SECOND LADY LEAD and JUVENILE LEAD]*. He's right! Move away from them!

THE SON. Do as you like. I'm out of this!

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! *[To MOTHER.]* You were saying you had entered...

THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. *[A hand at her chest, briefly.]* But the moment he saw me...

THE SON. Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

THE MOTHER. It's true, true. That's how it was.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

THE MOTHER. I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. *[Her hand at her chest.]*

THE FATHER *[going to SON in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

THE SON *[flat]*. I do nothing.

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

THE SON *[taking hold of the FATHER]*. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

The MOTHER, frightened, tries to separate them.

THE MOTHER *[both hands out, trying to part them]*. Please! please!

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the SON]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

THE SON *[the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry]*. What does it mean — this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency — that you would show the whole world our shame? I won't do it. I won't. The author who made us could not bear to stage this. Neither will I.

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

THE SON *[indicating FATHER]*. He did! I didn't!

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

THE SON. It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

THE SON. Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

THE SON. Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve]*. Well, well... walking in the garden...

THE SON *[exasperated]*. Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! *[The MOTHER's arms are empty — the Child-bundle is no longer in them, and she is the first in the room to feel its absence. Her hands close on nothing. She trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain before anyone has said why.]*

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the SON with increasing apprehension]*. The baby?

THE SON. There in the fountain...

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the MOTHER]*. She was following him at the moment...

THE MANAGER *[to the SON anxiously]*. And then you...

The stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, beneath the Son's narration. By the end of it, only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin.

THE SON *[the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer]*. I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. *[The STEP-DAUGHTER bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* Then... *[The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the Boy-chair behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is.]*

Lights snap back up at the cry that follows. The Boy is never seen dead — only the silhouette before, and the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and the silence the audience has just been made to look into.

The **MOTHER** does not cry out at once. She goes first to the basin and reaches down for the **CHILD-BUNDLE** in the water; then, hearing the **PLAYERS** take up the **BOY-CHAIR** behind her, she turns and reaches for that too. Her arms cannot hold both. The veil stays down over her face — she never lifts it herself, not even now. Only then does the sound come out of her.

THE MOTHER. My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

THE MANAGER *[pushing the PLAYERS aside while they lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

PLAYER 1 & PLAYER 3. He's dead! dead!

PLAYER 2. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry].* Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

THE MANAGER *[no commentary, no irony].* Pretence? Reality? *[He looks at the place where the Boy-chair stood.]* To hell with it all. *[He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.]*

✦
Curtain.

COLOPHON

This is a director's edition rewritten and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi. All directorial readings, scorings, adaptations, and production decisions in this edition — the chair-and-coat and the Child-bundle, the four-stage Father arc, the Step-Daughter's three cuts, the Mother's three silences, the Manager as audience-symbol, the Madame Pace arc from comic to chilling, the Lausanne anchoring, the rehearsal schedule, the Light & Sound score, and every part-note throughout — are his own work.

Underlying play: Luigi Pirandello, *Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore* (1921), in the public-domain Edward Storer English translation (1922). Source text: Project Gutenberg Australia, eBook No. 0608521h.html (November 2006).

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